# MODULE 4
# Validating Problem Spaces
# Testing Assumptions Before Building

ASSIGNMENT: Landing page live + pre-committed threshold + 100 target-segment visitors

A joint initiative by

## Check-In:

# How much new revenue did you sign?

## Check-In:

# What is your riskiest assumption atm?

# Today

Check-in — pain maps, segments, riskiest assumptions (15')

**IDEA 1 · Evidence has a hierarchy (10')**

**IDEA 2 · Commit the threshold BEFORE the test (10')**

**IDEA 3 · The landing page is an experiment, not marketing (15')**

**IDEA 4 · Measure what matters, not what flatters (10')**

Case · Dropbox: a 3-minute video as the experiment (30')

Workshop · Landing Page Sprint — live page today (90')

Wrap-up · threshold in the log, traffic plan set (5')

# Recap from last time

# Show us where you‘re at in 3 Minutes or less!

| What did you do? | What did you learn? | How can we help? |
| --- | --- | --- |

Make it credible:

1. Facts: Statistics or Research: What do they say? What does it mean? Where are they from?
2. Numbers: Usage or Surveys: How were they reported? How did they change? Why is it relevant?
3. Quotes: Interviews or Testemonials: What did they say? Why did they say it? What could this mean?
4. Images: Screenshots or Users: What happened? What changed? Why is it relevant?

# IDEA 1: Evidence has a hierarchy

Opinions < conversations < behavior < money. Every level up costs more effort and lies less.

Last week you collected words. This week you buy behavior: clicks and signups from strangers.

# Prototyping Problems; cool, but why?

# Why Validation Matters

**42%**

of startups fail because no market need

*CB Insights, 2023*

**70%**

of new products fail within the first year

*Harvard Business Review*

**10x**

cheaper to fix problems before building

*Steve Blank*

*"Fall in love with the problem, not the solution." — Uri Levine, Waze founder*

# The Validation Mindset

*Shift from confirmation to discovery*

| CONFIRMATION MODE | DISCOVERY MODE |
| --- | --- |
| ✗ "Let me prove my idea is great" | ✓ "Let me learn what's true" |
| ✗ Asking leading questions | ✓ Asking open questions |
| ✗ Ignoring negative signals | ✓ Celebrating negative signals |
| ✗ Building first, asking later | ✓ Testing before building |

**Goal:** Find reasons your idea WON'T work (before you waste months building it)

# The Execution ↔ Research Spectrum

Startups differ in WHAT is uncertain — not in WHETHER they must validate

**PURE EXECUTION** → **RESEARCH-HEAVY**

| AMAZON · 1994 | AIRBNB · 2008 | TESLA · 2008 | SPACEX / OPENAI |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Execution risk** | **Behavior risk** | **Engineering risk** | **Research risk** |
| Demand for books was proven — the bet was logistics. Shipped within a year. | “Will strangers sleep at strangers' homes?” Tested with 3 air mattresses. | Took $100k Roadster deposits years before series production. | NASA contract before reaching orbit; GPT-3 shipped as a paid API experiment. |

**Your position changes WHAT you validate first — never WHETHER. All four validated with real commitments, fast.**

# Revenue Is Validation — On Every Path

B2B SaaS or deep tech: the first steps are identical

**SHARED START** **Discovery interviews → problem-space landing page → someone commits time, data or money**

## B2B SAAS PATH

Demo calls with signups from your page

Paid pilot (€500–5k) with 2–3 design partners

Annual contract — MRR starts compounding

**Customers pay you to keep solving**

## DEEP TECH PATH

LOIs from industry partners

Grants & development contracts (EIC, SPRIND, ESA)

Funded pilot with a reference customer

**Partners pay you to de-risk the technology**

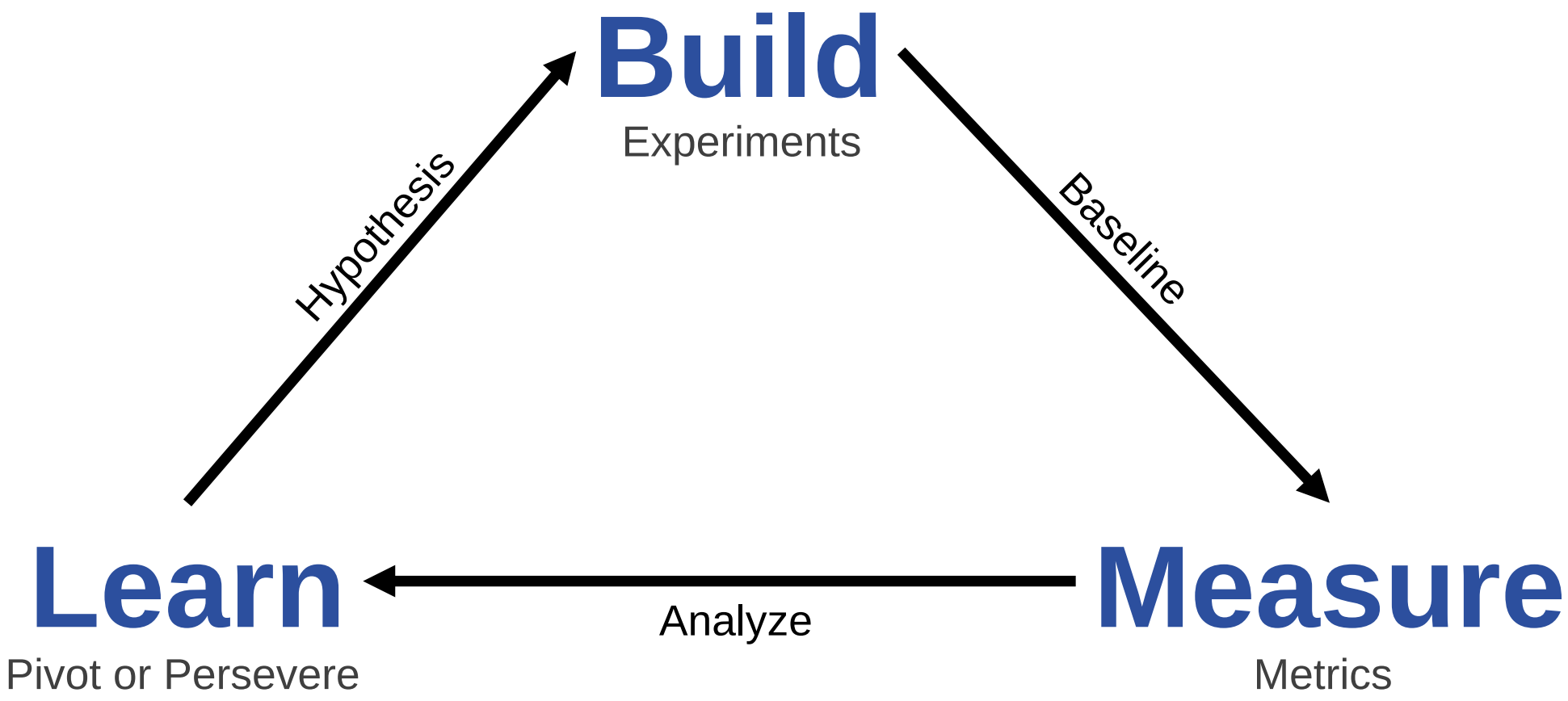
**Money is the only signal that can't lie: a deposit, a pilot fee, a grant, a signed LOI — all are revenue-shaped evidence.**

# Hierarchy of Evidence

*Not all validation is created equal*

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | **Paying Customers** | *Someone paid you money* | **Strongest** |
| 4 | **Letter of Intent** | *Written commitment to buy* | **Strong** |
| 3 | **Signup / Waitlist** | *Email or contact given* | **Medium** |
| 2 | **Qualitative Interviews** | *Deep conversations (n=5-10)* | **Weak** |
| 1 | **Anecdotal Evidence** | *"My friend said..."* | **Weakest** |

# The Build-Measure-Learn Loop



# IDEA 2: Commit the threshold first

Decide what 'no' looks like BEFORE you see the data — or every result will feel like 'almost'.

One sentence, one number, dated, in the Kill Criteria Log. Tonight, before the first ad euro.

# From Assumptions to Hypotheses

| Assumption (Vague) | → | Hypothesis (Testable) |
|---|---|---|
| *"People want this"* | → | **"50% of SMB owners spend >5h/week on X"** |
| *"They'll pay for it"* | → | **"10% will pay $50/month to solve X"** |
| *"We can build it"* | → | **"We can ship MVP in 2 weeks with AI"** |
| *"Marketing will work"* | → | **"LinkedIn ads convert at 2% CTR"** |

**Formula:** *"We believe [specific customer] will [specific behavior] because [reason], and we'll know this when [measurable outcome]"*

# Write the number before you look

**The sentence: 'If fewer than __% of target-segment visitors sign up, we pivot the segment (or the promise).'**

Committed · dated · unchangeable — in the Kill Criteria Log tab of your Toolkit. Before launch, not after.

Why: after the fact, 6% feels like 'nearly 10%'. Before the fact, 6% is a decision.

Module 05 opens with your threshold read out loud, next to your actual number. No self-graded homework.

Benchmark for orientation: cold traffic to a validation page converts ~5–15% when the promise lands (practitioner heuristic).

# What the evidence says

The RCT behind this whole course (Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina 2020, Management Science): founders trained to state hypotheses, run tests and COMMIT decision rules earned more revenue and pivoted more decisively than the control group.

**The treatment group's edge wasn't intelligence. It was thresholds.**

Replicated across multiple RCTs since (2024 meta-work). You're not doing homework — you're running the protocol that measurably works.

# IDEA 3: The landing page is an experiment

One promise, one call-to-action, one segment — built from your interviews' verbatim language.

Ship it in under an hour. The page isn't the product; the conversion rate is.

# Landing Page Validation

*Scale your validation beyond 1:1 interviews*

**Traffic** → **Landing Page** → **Signup** **= Validated Interest**

- ✓ Tests real behavior (not hypothetical "would you...")
- ✓ Scalable: reach 100+ people in days, not weeks
- ✓ Provides quantitative data (conversion rates)
- ✓ Forces you to articulate your value proposition

**Benchmark:** 5-10% signup rate = strong problem validation

# The Problem-Space Landing Page

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **HEADLINE** | Be specific. Name the pain.<br>"[Customer] struggle with [Problem]" |
| 2 | **SUBHEAD** | Empathize with the problem.<br>Show you understand their world. |
| 3 | **THE PROMISE** | "We're building a solution."<br>Hint at solution, don't detail it. |
| 4 | **CTA** | Email signup / Waitlist.<br>"Get early access" or "Join waitlist" |
| 5 | **SOCIAL PROOF** | Optional: logos, testimonials.<br>Even "We're students at TUM" works. |

*Keep it simple: 1 page, 1 CTA, <5 minutes to read*

# Tools: Ship in < 1 Hour

## Umso/Carrd…

**$19/yr**

Fastest for simple pages
Custom domain included

carrd.co

## Framer

**Free tier**

More design control
AI-assisted design

framer.com

## Lovable

**AI credits**

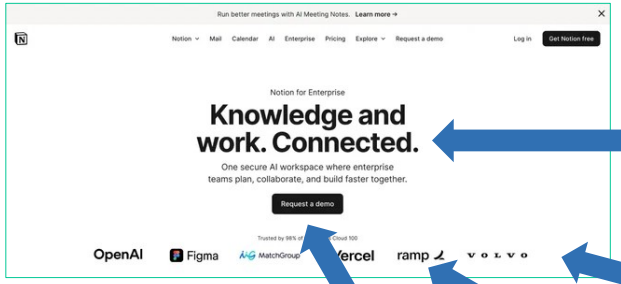
Full landing page from prompt
"Vibe coding" approach

lovable.dev

*Pro tip: Use Tally.so or Typeform for the email capture form. Connect to Google Sheets for easy data collection.*

# Landing Page Content

# So what does that look like



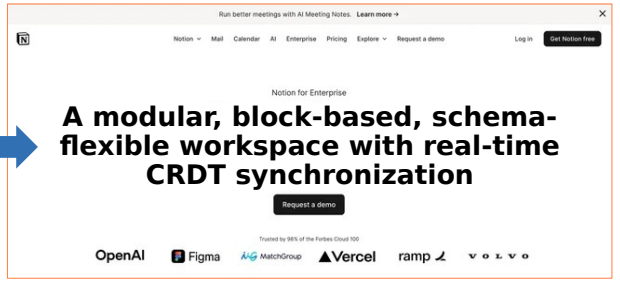

“Yes, Knowledge Management is a problem for us, too!“

No sign of actual produc

Psychological wizzardry

Call to Action – always Call to Action

What their German Engineer proposed



# Vibe-coded quantitative Problem Validation

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# IDEA 4: Measure what matters

Visits flatter. Conversion informs. Only target-segment traffic counts — keep the UTM report.

Signups are level-3 evidence: they buy you the right to build next week. They are not a company yet.

# Getting Traffic to Your Page

*Free & fast channels for validation*

| LinkedIn | Reddit / Communities | Direct Outreach |
| --- | --- | --- |
| • Post about the problem (not your solution)<br>• DM people in your target segment<br>• 50-100 impressions/post possible | • Find subreddits where customers hang out<br>• Provide value first, then share page<br>• Be genuine, not spammy | • Email 20 people directly<br>• Personalize each message<br>• Ask for feedback, not signups |

**Goal:** 100-200 visitors → 10-20 signups = validated interest

# Metrics That Matter

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Conversion Rate** | *Signups ÷ Visitors* | **>5% = strong** | **2-5% = OK** | **<2% = weak** |
| **Time on Page** | *How long they read* | **>1 min = engaged** | **<30s = wrong message** | |
| **Scroll Depth** | *How far they scroll* | **>50% = interested** | | |
| **Click-to-Open** | *For email follow-ups* | **>20% = engaged list** | | |

*Tools: Google Analytics (free), Hotjar (free tier), Posthog (free tier)*

# From Signups to First Revenue

What your landing page signups become next

**M4 · TODAY**

Landing page live, signups flowing — drive 100+ visitors this week

→

**M5–6 · SOLUTION**

Signups become prototype testers for your first solution experiments

→

**M7–8 · TRACTION**

Rapid validation + first users — usage becomes the new evidence

→

**M9+ · REVENUE**

First paying customer: the only validation that can't lie

**Talk to every signup within 7 days — warm leads decay fast. Your M3 interviewees should already be on this list.**

# END RECAP — today in four lines

1 · Up the hierarchy: words → behavior. Buy signals from strangers.

2 · Threshold before test — one number, dated, in the log

3 · The page is an experiment: one promise, one CTA, interview language

4 · Target-segment conversion is the only number that matters

**This week: 100+ real visitors, honest read-out, bring the UTM report. M05 decides with your data.**

# Workshop: Landing Page Sprint (90 min)

Agenda lives in M04_Workshop_Landing-Page-Sprint.md. Pre-work required: accounts created, interview quotes ready, €50 budget source named.

Copy first, then build: headline = the sharpest verbatim quote from your interviews.

**Must produce: live page + analytics wired + threshold committed + ad campaign planned.**

Kill criteria: your page promises something no interviewee ever asked for.

# Wrapup & Checkout

# This week — M04_Homework.md

1. Build a Landingpage about your problem
2. Launch it to the web – it’s 10€ well spend
3. Generate at least 7 CTA interactions each week
4. Follow up with the visitors and learn more

# Thank You!

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# APPENDIX — original slides (51 restored as images)

These pages from the pre-rework deck are not in the current flow. Source snapshot: Instructor/original-decks/M04_Lecture_ORIGINAL.pdf.

**Mark each: KEEP (design pass rebuilds it properly, editable) or KILL. Nothing gets deleted without your call.**

## Check-In:

# What is your Energy Level Today?

## Check-In:

# What was your most exciting finding?

## Check-In:

# What was your biggest road blocker?

## Check-In:

# How many users did you talk to?

FRAMEWORK

# Jobs-to-be-Done: "Hire" Products

> People don't buy products. They **HIRE** products to do a job.

### ⚙ Functional

What the product literally does for me

### ♥ Emotional

How it makes me feel

### 👥 Social

How others see me when I use it

## The Drill Example

**"I need a drill"**

*Surface request*

→

**"I need a hole"**

*Functional job*

→

**"I want to hang a picture"**

*Real goal*

→

**"I want to feel at home"**

*Emotional job*

*Christensen, C. (2016). Competing Against Luck. Harper Business.*

# Finding an Audience

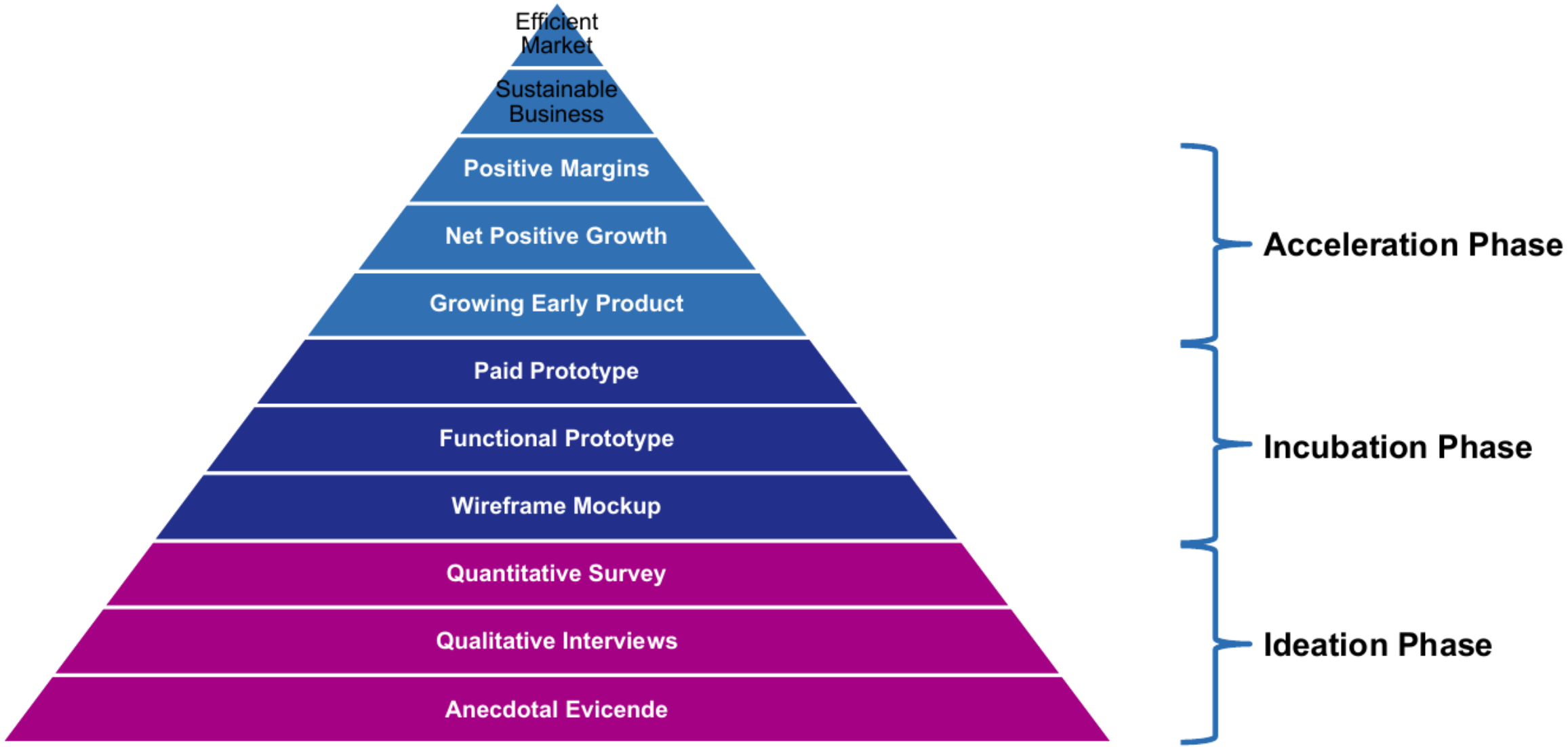
- **Better done than perfect:** Use who you can find, even if they are not your perfect customer
- **Know your customers:** B2B goes to canteens, B2C sit in cafees, when do they have 10 mins
- **Give first, take second:** Offer them a beverage or snack for their time
- **Set yourself a target:** Don‘t leave before you spend at least 10 minutes with at least 7 people
- **Always follow through:** Never leave a loose end



# Get out of the building to get every day at least 7 interactions

# Your Presentations

# Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup



# Your advantage, your success factor, your edge: Execution Speed

# Hirarchy of evidence in the lean startup



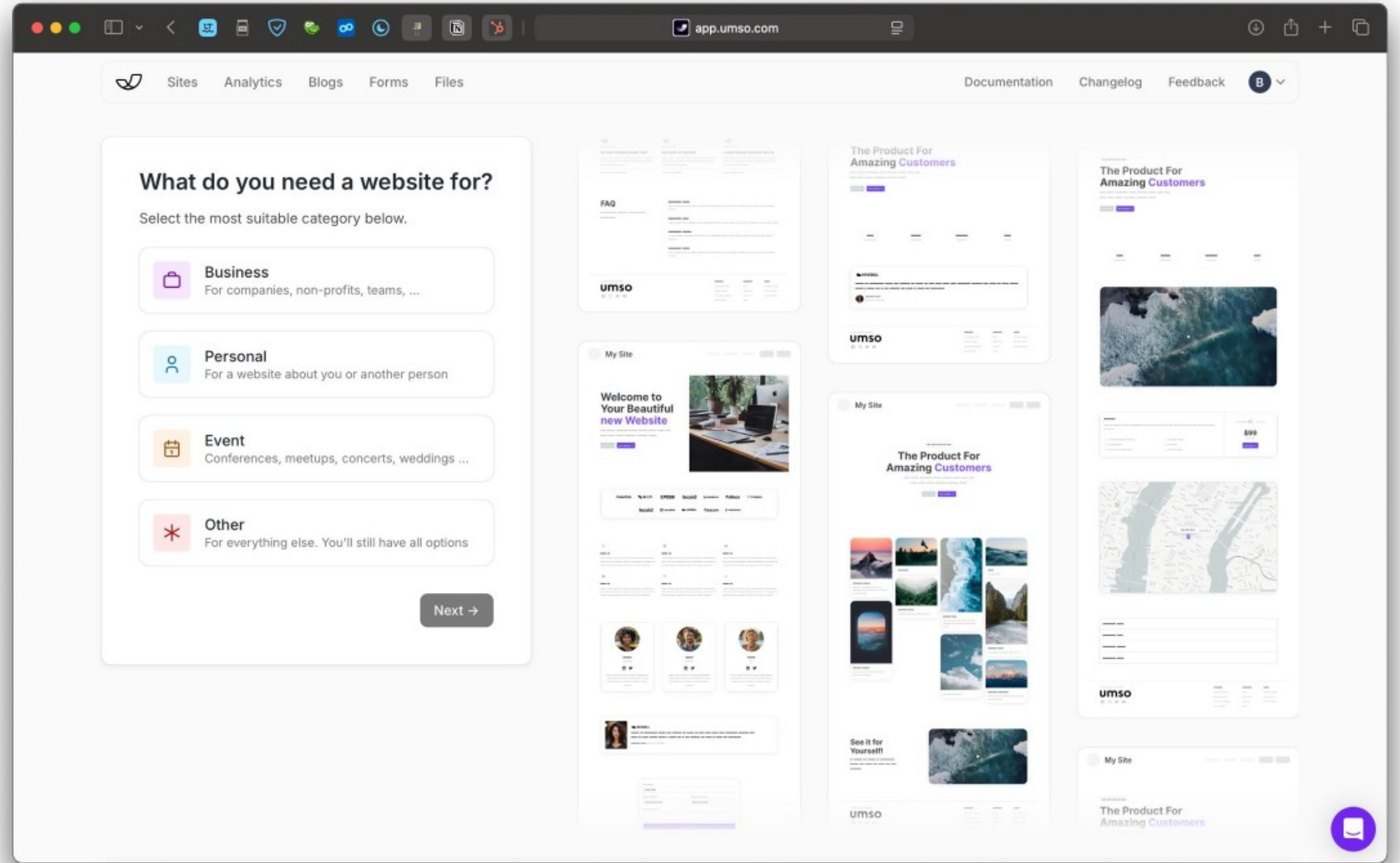

**Acceleration Phase**

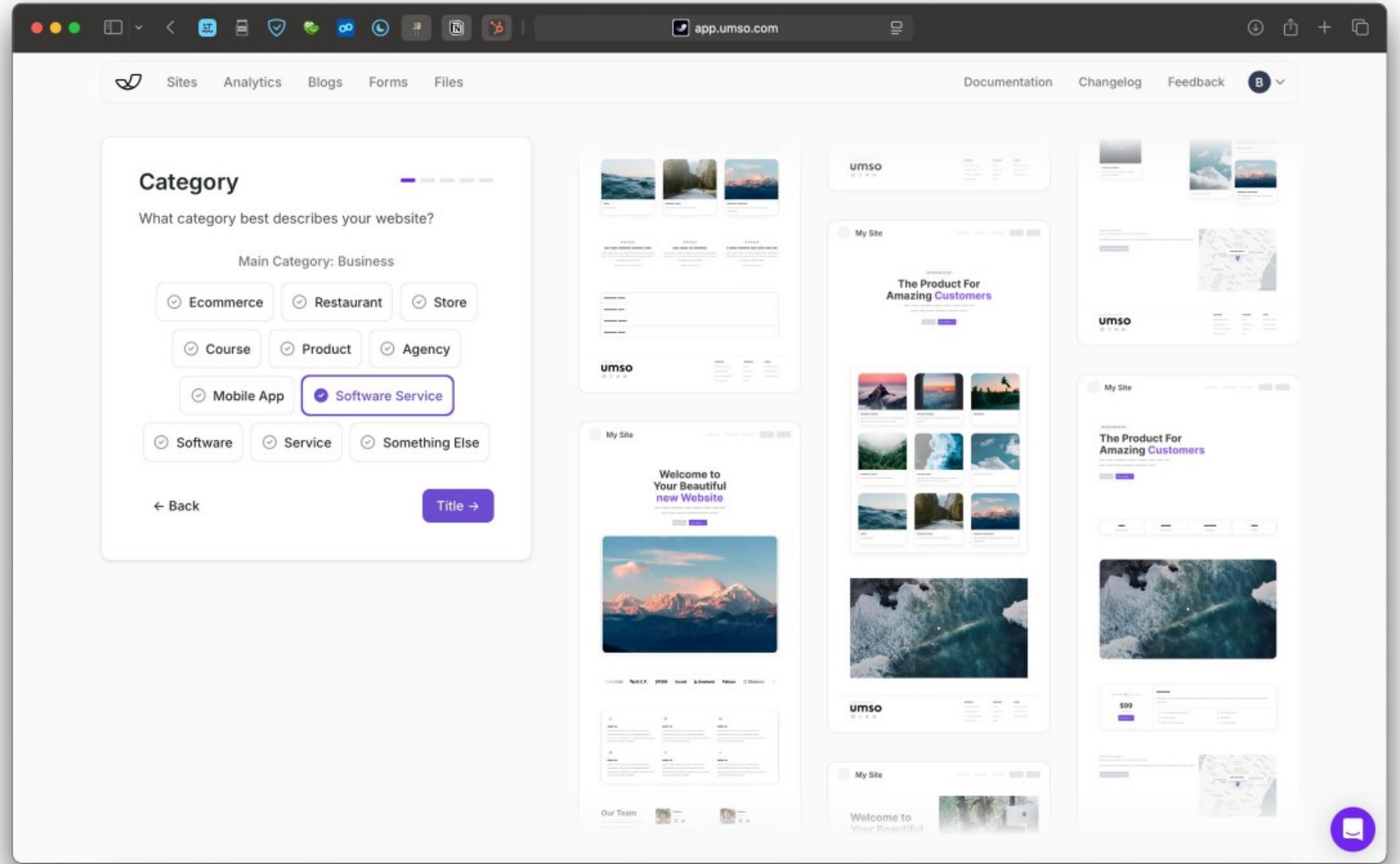
**Incubation Phase**

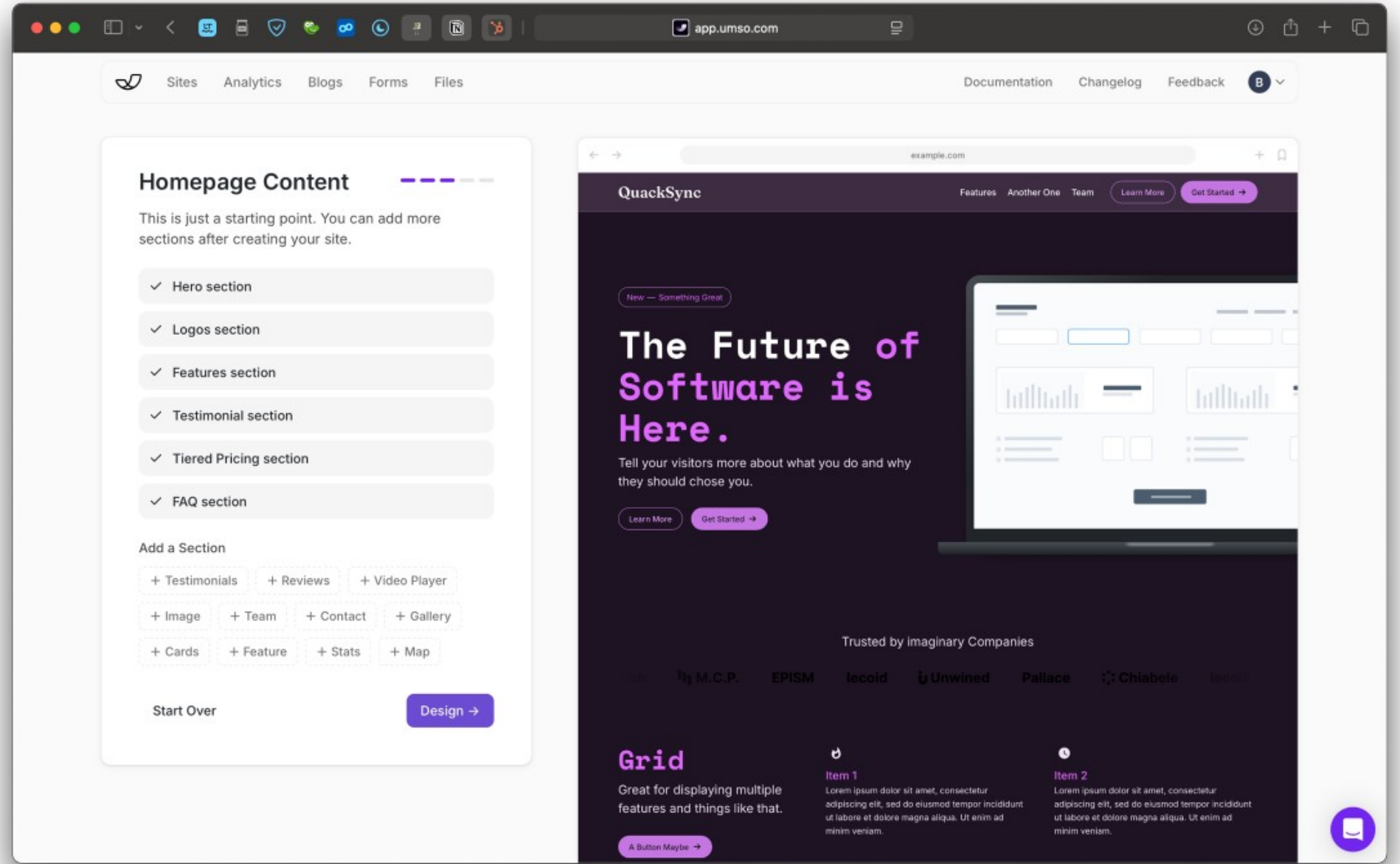
**Ideation Phase**

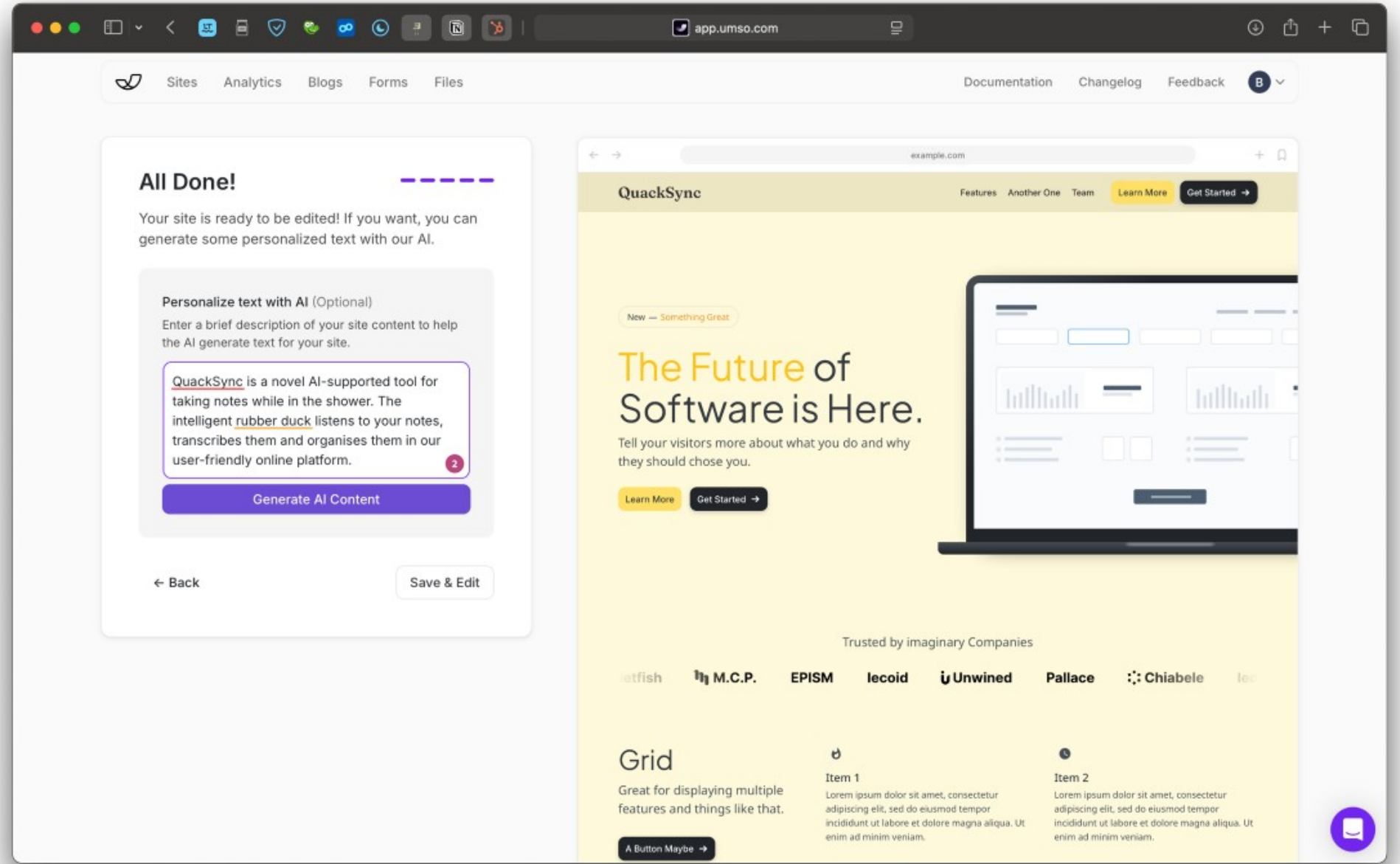
# Tooling to test a problem space => **Theory testing!**

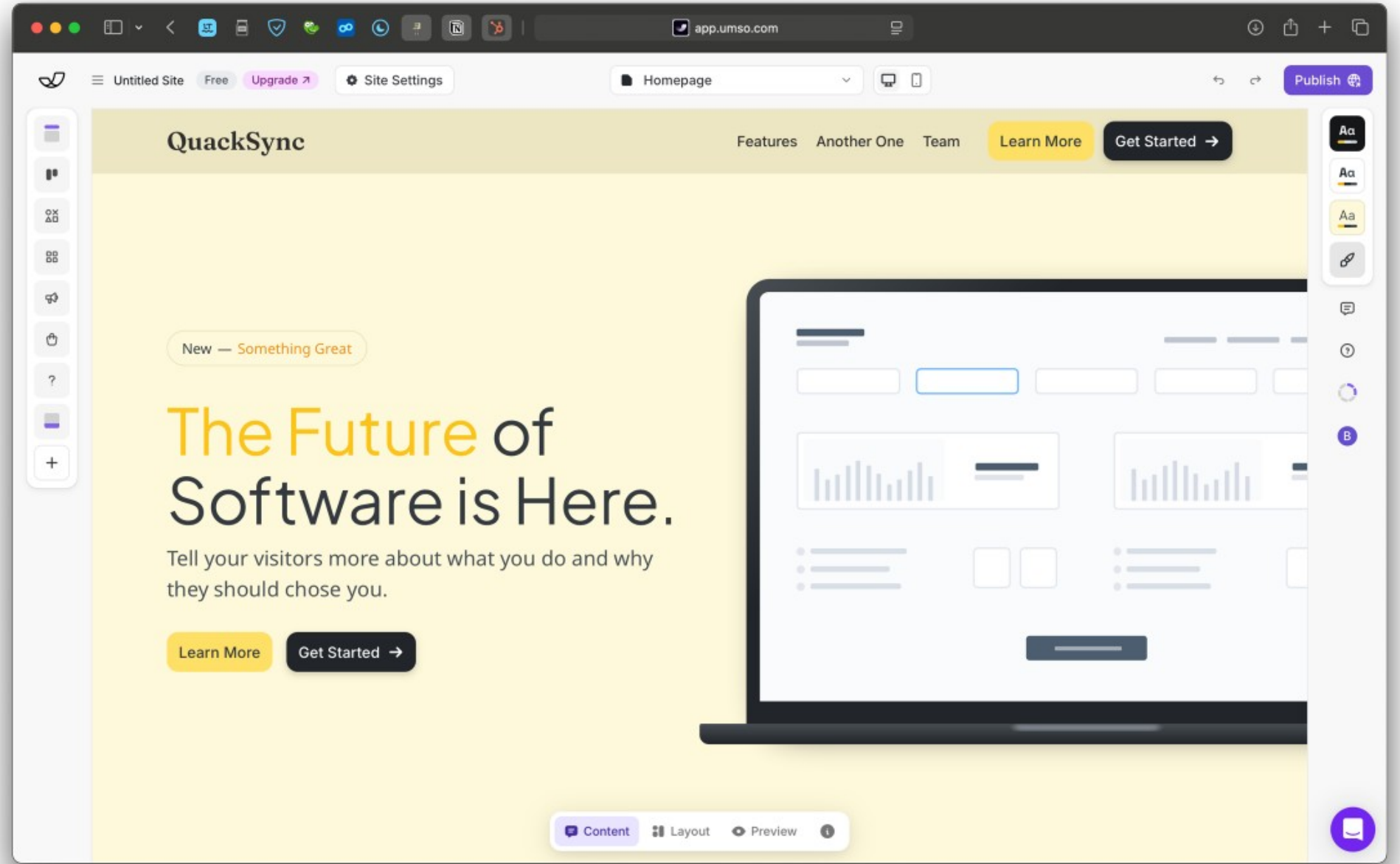


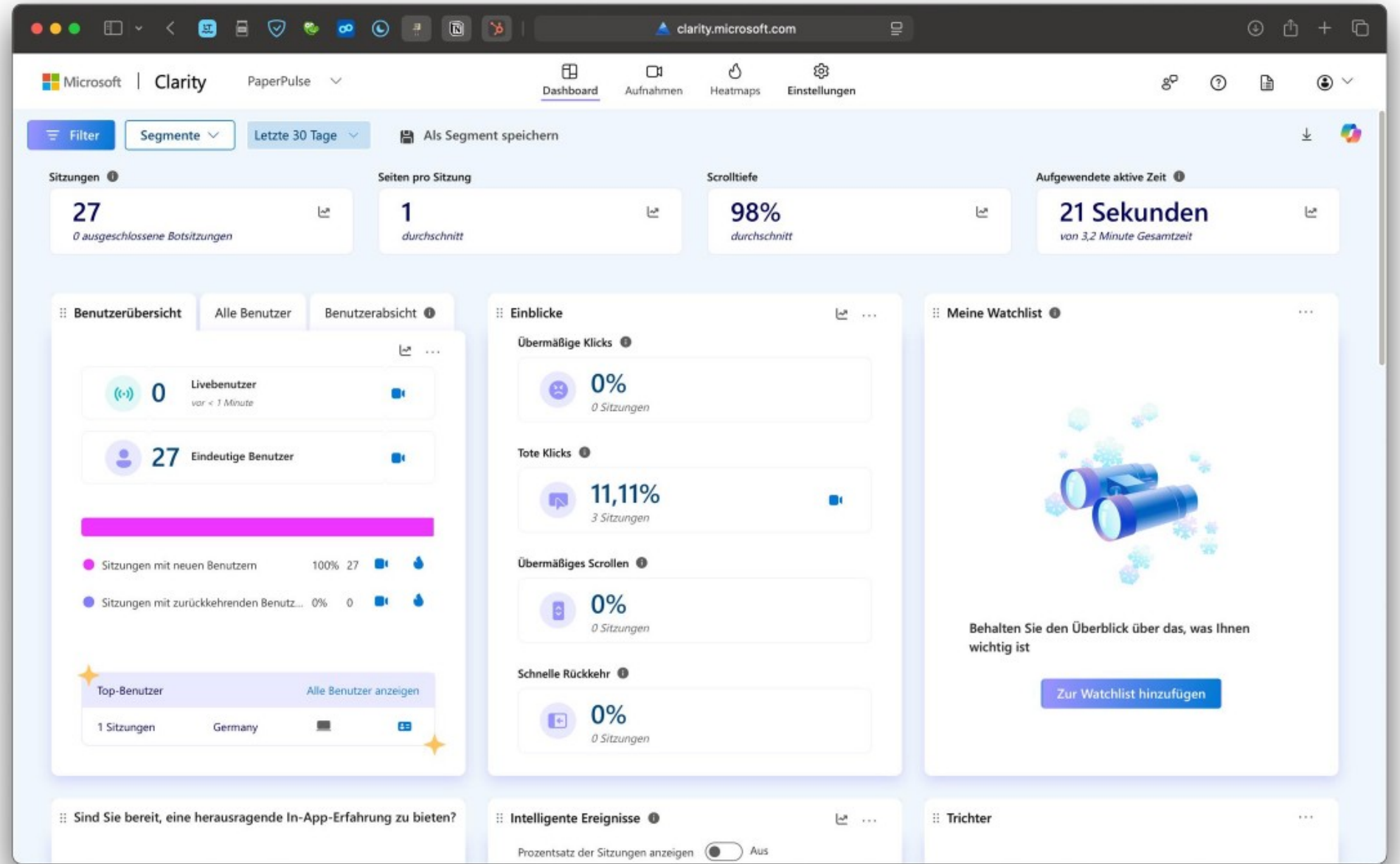

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Analytics
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What do you need a website for?
Select the most suitable category below.
Business
For companies, non-profits, teams, ...
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For a website about you or another person
Event
Conferences, meetups, concerts, weddings ...
Other
For everything else. You'll still have all options
Next →
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The Product For
Amazing Customers
My Site
Welcome to
Your Beautiful
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See it for
Yourself!

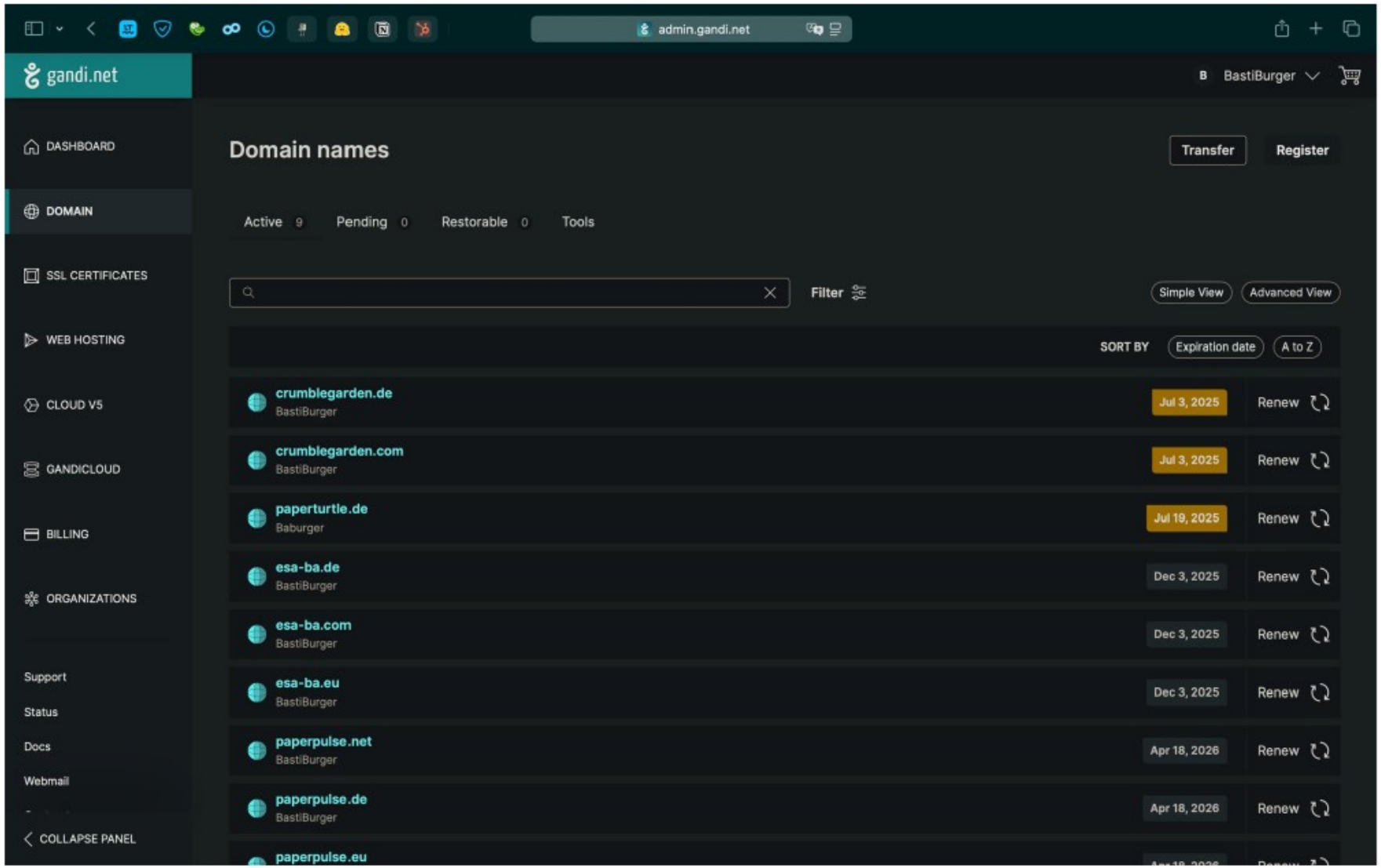

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Changelog
Feedback
Category
What category best describes your website?
Main Category: Business
Ecommerce
Restaurant
Store
Course
Product
Agency
Mobile App
Software Service
Software
Service
Something Else
← Back
Title →
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My Site
The Product For Amazing Customers
Welcome to Your Beautiful new Website
Our Team


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Feedback
Homepage Content
This is just a starting point. You can add more sections after creating your site.
Hero section
Logos section
Features section
Testimonial section
Tiered Pricing section
FAQ section
Add a Section
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+ Reviews
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Start Over
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Get Started →
New — Something Great
The Future of Software is Here.
Tell your visitors more about what you do and why they should chose you.
Learn More
Get Started →
Trusted by imaginary Companies
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Great for displaying multiple features and things like that.
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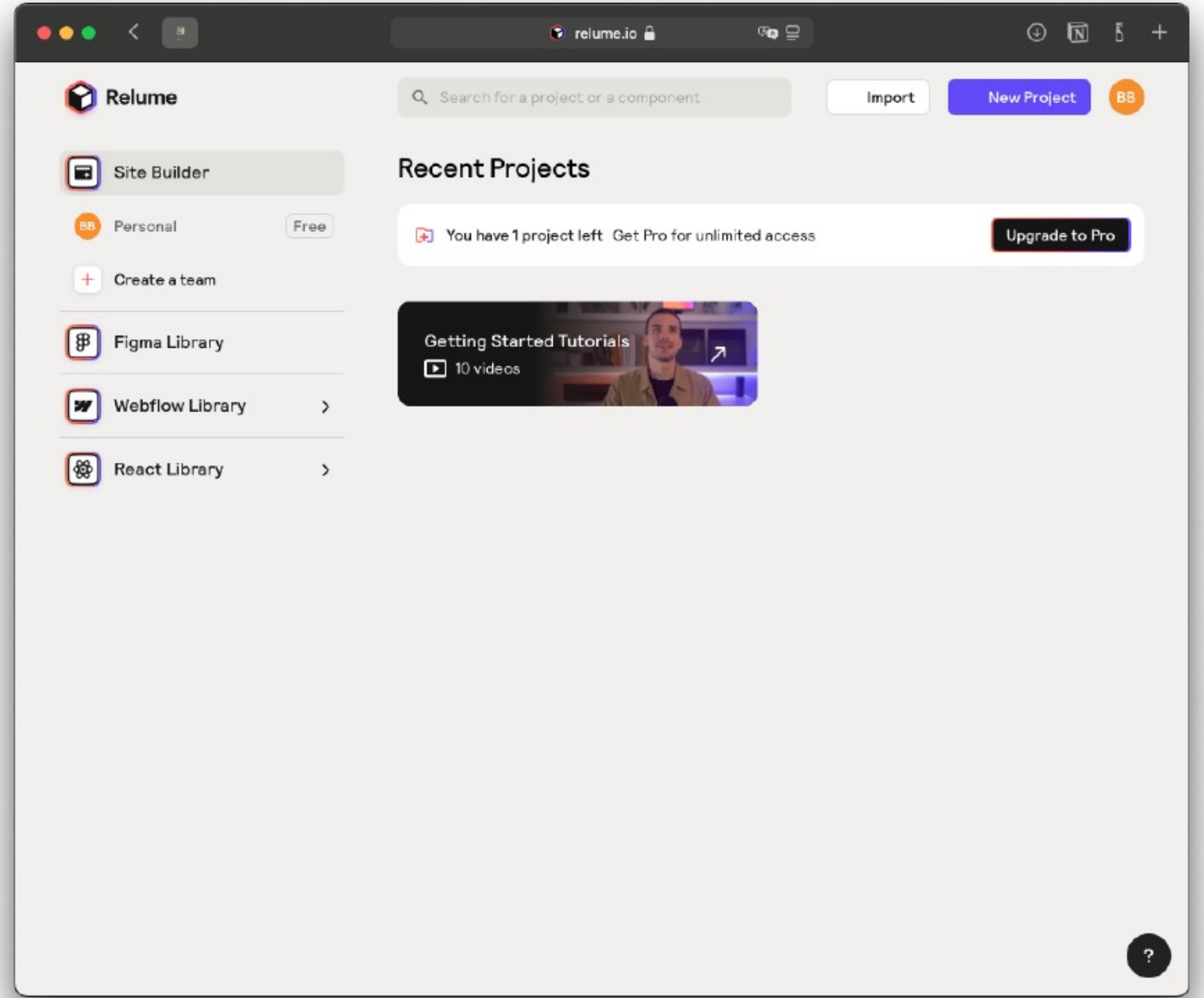

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All Done!
Your site is ready to be edited! If you want, you can generate some personalized text with our AI.
Personalize text with AI (Optional)
Enter a brief description of your site content to help the AI generate text for your site.
QuackSync is a novel AI-supported tool for taking notes while in the shower. The intelligent rubber duck listens to your notes, transcribes them and organises them in our user-friendly online platform.
Generate AI Content
← Back
Save & Edit
example.com
QuackSync
Features
Another One
Team
Learn More
Get Started →
New — Something Great
The Future of Software is Here.
Tell your visitors more about what you do and why they should chose you.
Learn More
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Trusted by imaginary Companies
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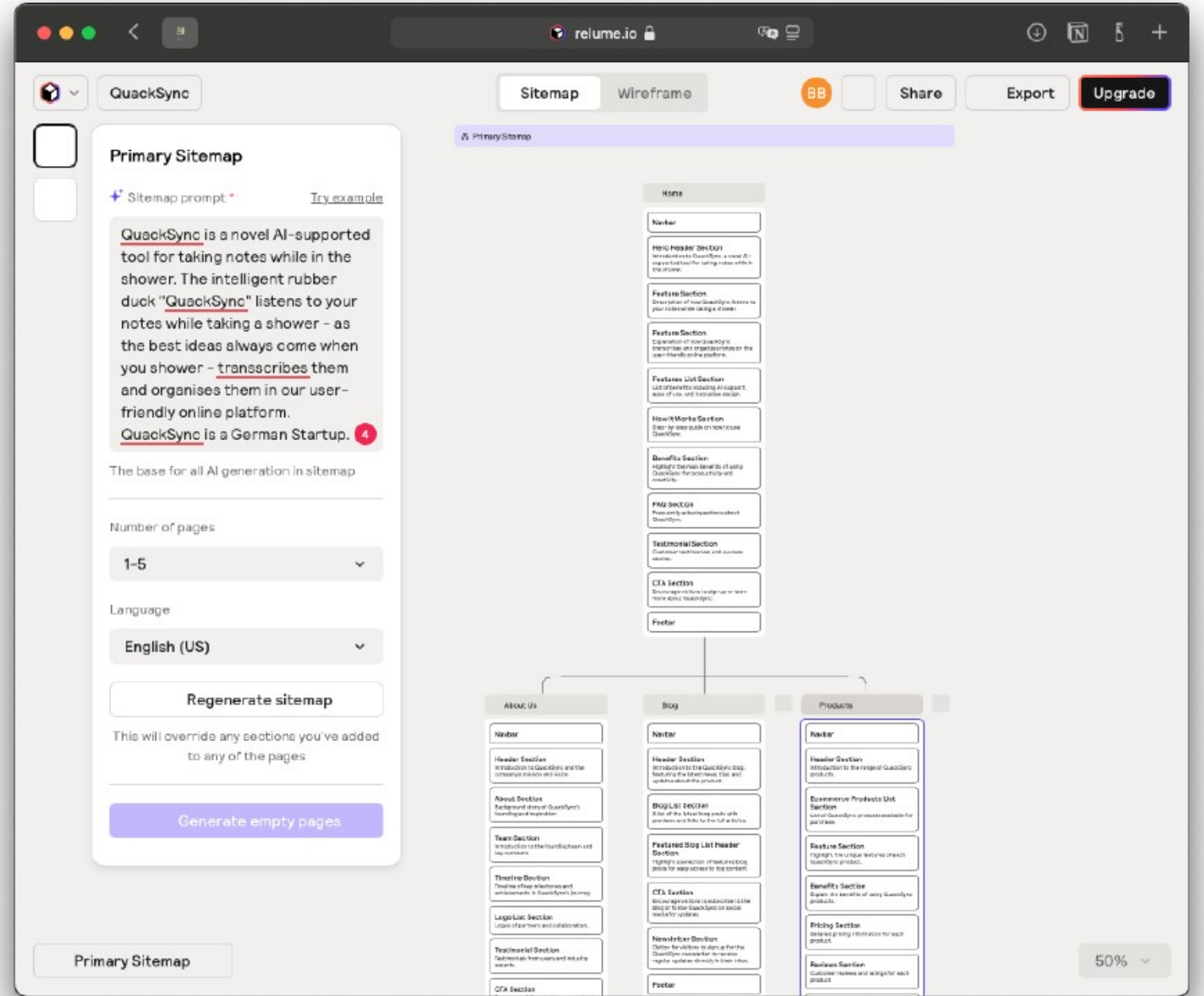

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The Future of Software is Here.
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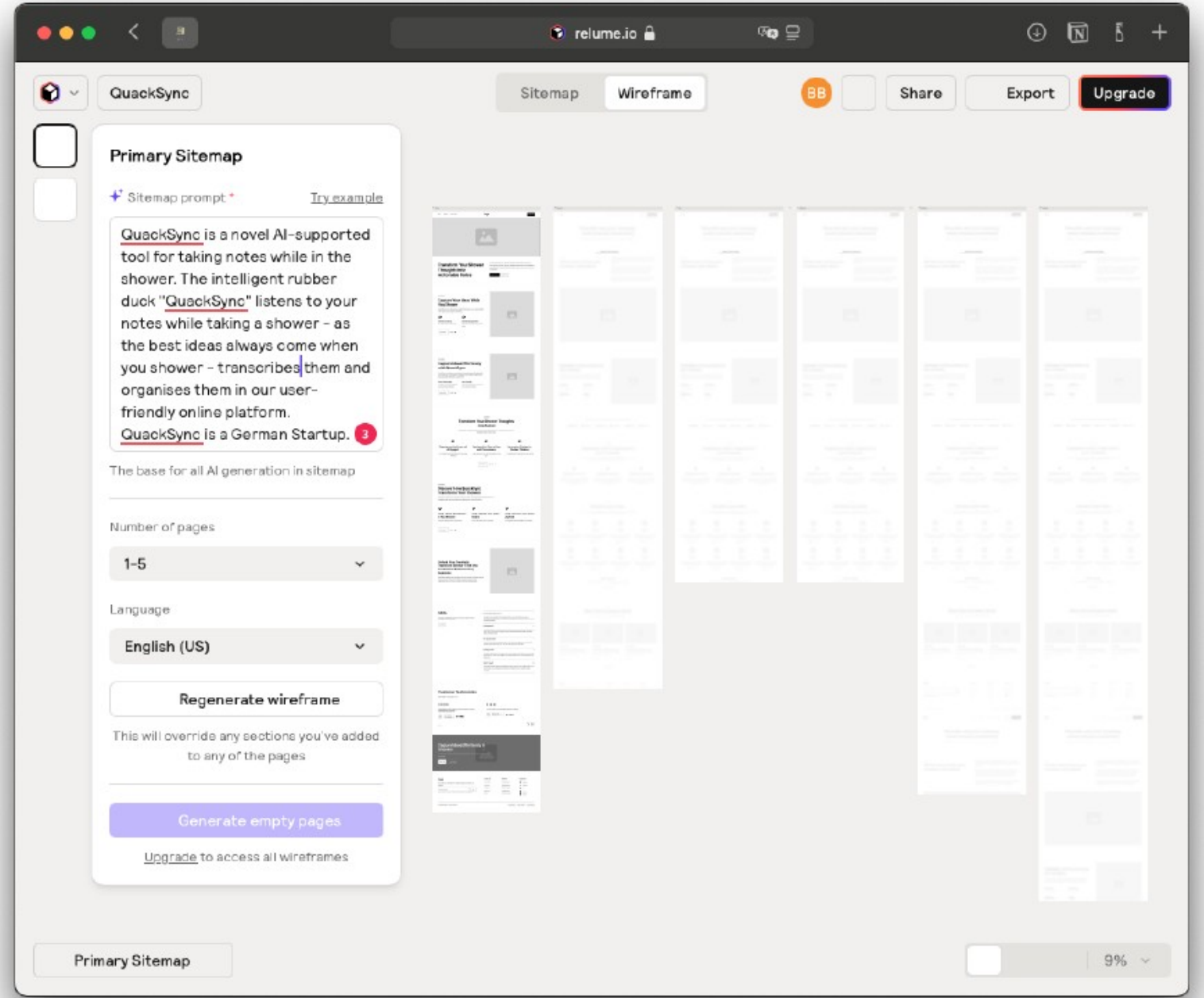

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Letzte 30 Tage
Als Segment speichern
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0 ausgeschlossene Botsitzungen
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von 3,2 Minute Gesamtzeit
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Eindeutige Benutzer
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100% 27
Sitzungen mit zurückkehrenden Benutz...
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0 Sitzungen
Tote Klicks
11,11%
3 Sitzungen
Übermäßiges Scrollen
0%
0 Sitzungen
Schnelle Rückkehr
0%
0 Sitzungen
Meine Watchlist
Behalten Sie den Überblick über das, was Ihnen wichtig ist
Zur Watchlist hinzufügen
Sind Sie bereit, eine herausragende In-App-Erfahrung zu bieten?
Intelligente Ereignisse
Prozentsatz der Sitzungen anzeigen
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paperpulse.de
BastiBurger
Apr 18, 2026
Renew
paperpulse.eu

# Building later webpages to convert to your Solution Space


relume.io
Relume
Search for a project or a component
Import
New Project
BB
Site Builder
Personal
Free
Create a team
Figma Library
Webflow Library
React Library
Recent Projects
You have 1 project left Get Pro for unlimited access
Upgrade to Pro
Getting Started Tutorials
10 videos
?


relume.io
QuackSync
Sitemap
Wireframe
BB
Share
Export
Upgrade
Primary Sitemap
Sitemap prompt *
Try example
QuackSync is a novel AI-supported tool for taking notes while in the shower. The intelligent rubber duck "QuackSync" listens to your notes while taking a shower - as the best ideas always come when you shower - transscribes them and organises them in our user-friendly online platform.
QuackSync is a German Startup.
4
The base for all AI generation in sitemap
Number of pages
1-5
Language
English (US)
Regenerate sitemap
This will override any sections you've added to any of the pages
Generate empty pages
Primary Sitemap
Home
About Us
Blog
Products
50%


relume.io
QuackSync
Sitemap
Wireframe
BB
Share
Export
Upgrade
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Sitemap prompt *
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3
The base for all AI generation in sitemap
Number of pages
1-5
Language
English (US)
Regenerate wireframe
This will override any sections you've added to any of the pages
Generate empty pages
Upgrade to access all wireframes
Primary Sitemap
9%

relume.io

Untitled – Framer

## Export to Figma



Add your Sitemaps or Wireframes in Figma, open the Relume Figma Kit, install the plugin, and access all your projects directly from it.

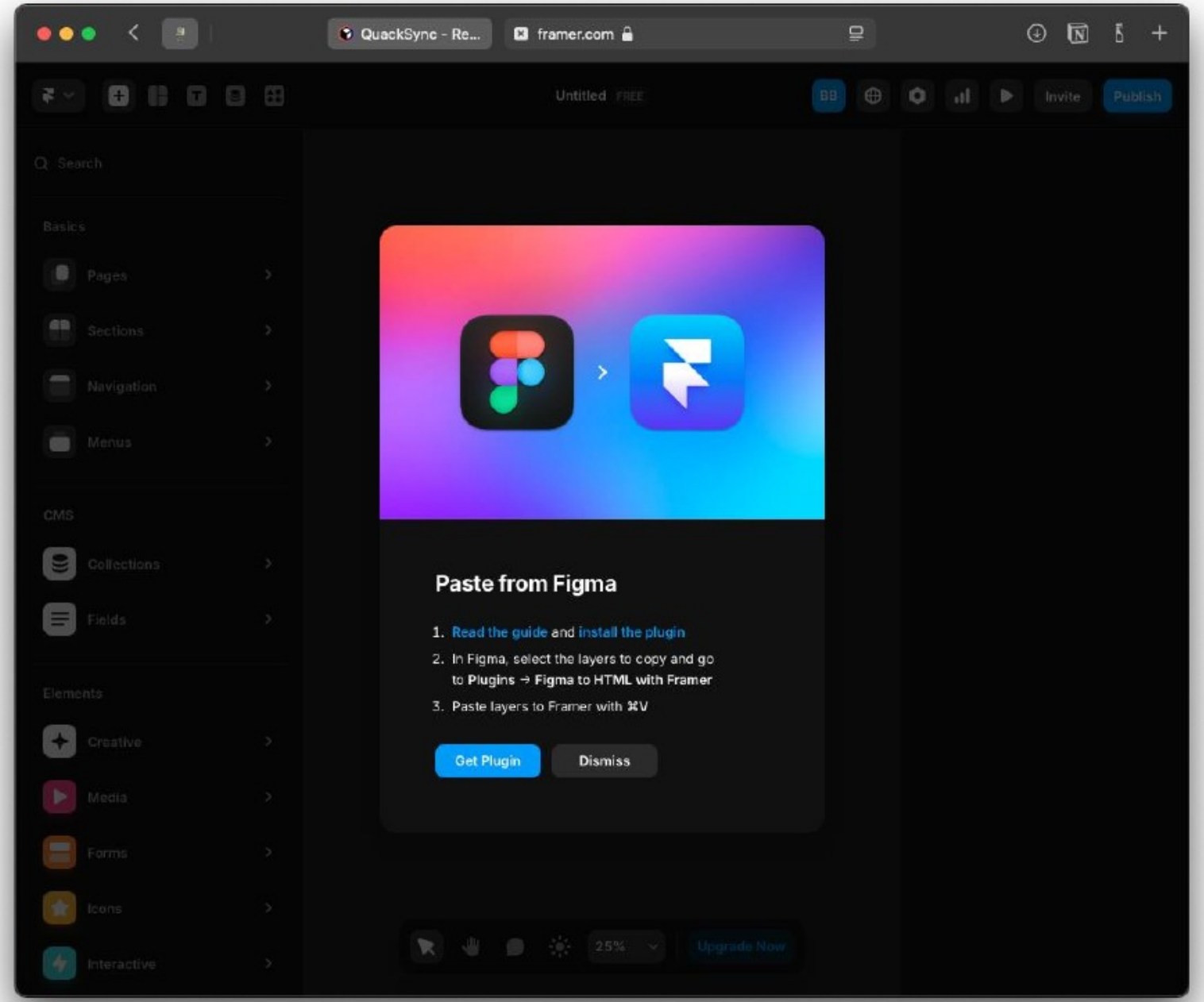
- Open the Relume Figma Kit.

  Open in Figma

- Install the Relume Figma Plugin.

  Install plugin

- Add your Sitemap or Wireframes into Figma.


QuackSync - Re...
framer.com
Untitled FREE
Invite
Publish
Search
Basics
Pages
Sections
Navigation
Menus
CMS
Collections
Fields
Elements
Creative
Media
Forms
Icons
Interactive
Paste from Figma
1. Read the guide and install the plugin
2. In Figma, select the layers to copy and go to Plugins → Figma to HTML with Framer
3. Paste layers to Framer with ⌘V
Get Plugin
Dismiss
25%
Upgrade Now

receptive-data-688692.framer.app

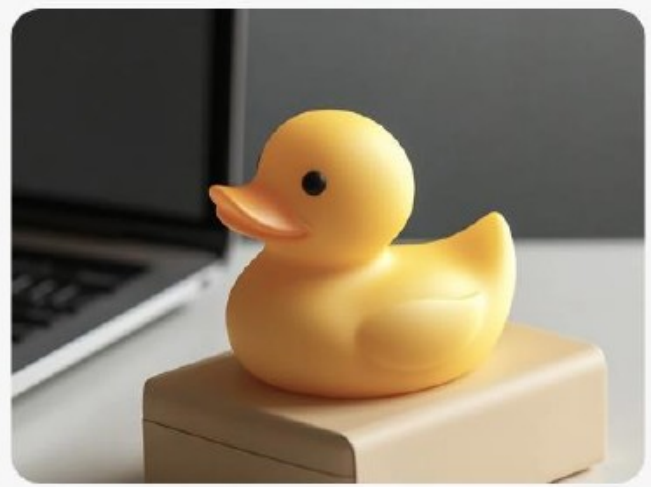


# Your new friend

Waterproof, friendly, always at your side.
QuackSync was build to capture your ideas while in the shower or anywhere really.

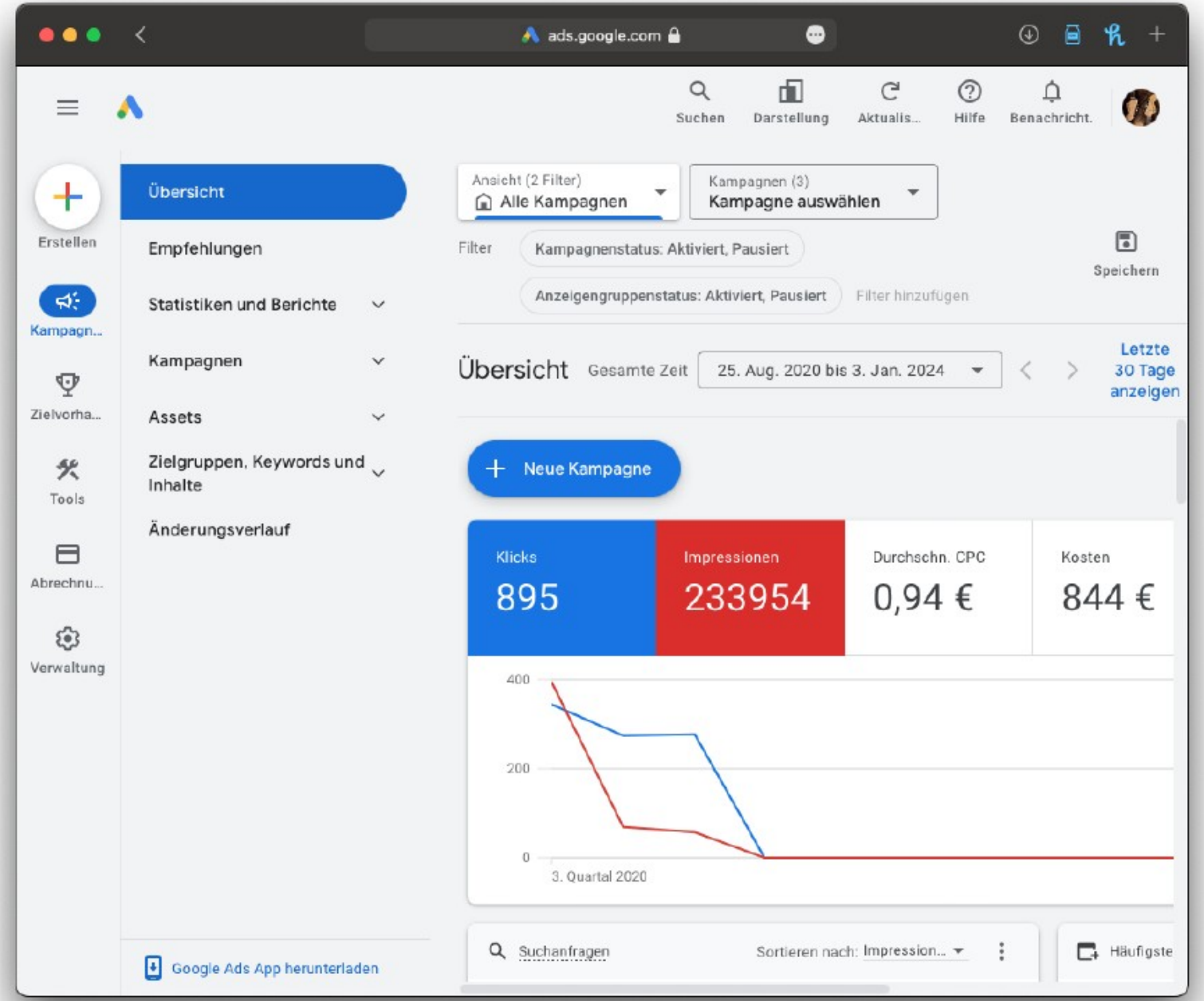
## Plug and Play

QuackSync transcribes, summarises and organises all your ideas for you. No subscription required.



Made in Framer

VENTURE LABS


ads.google.com
Suchen
Darstellung
Aktualis...
Hilfe
Benachricht.
Erstellen
Kampagn...
Zielvorha...
Tools
Abrechnu...
Verwaltung
Übersicht
Empfehlungen
Statistiken und Berichte
Kampagnen
Assets
Zielgruppen, Keywords und Inhalte
Änderungsverlauf
Google Ads App herunterladen
Ansicht (2 Filter)
Alle Kampagnen
Kampagnen (3)
Kampagne auswählen
Filter
Kampagnenstatus: Aktiviert, Pausiert
Anzeigengruppenstatus: Aktiviert, Pausiert
Filter hinzufügen
Speichern
Übersicht
Gesamte Zeit
25. Aug. 2020 bis 3. Jan. 2024
Letzte 30 Tage anzeigen
Neue Kampagne
Klicks
895
Impressionen
233954
Durchschn. CPC
0,94 €
Kosten
844 €
400
200
0
3. Quartal 2020
Suchanfragen
Sortieren nach: Impression...
Häufigste

# Do you need a brand name?

Shoe Dog

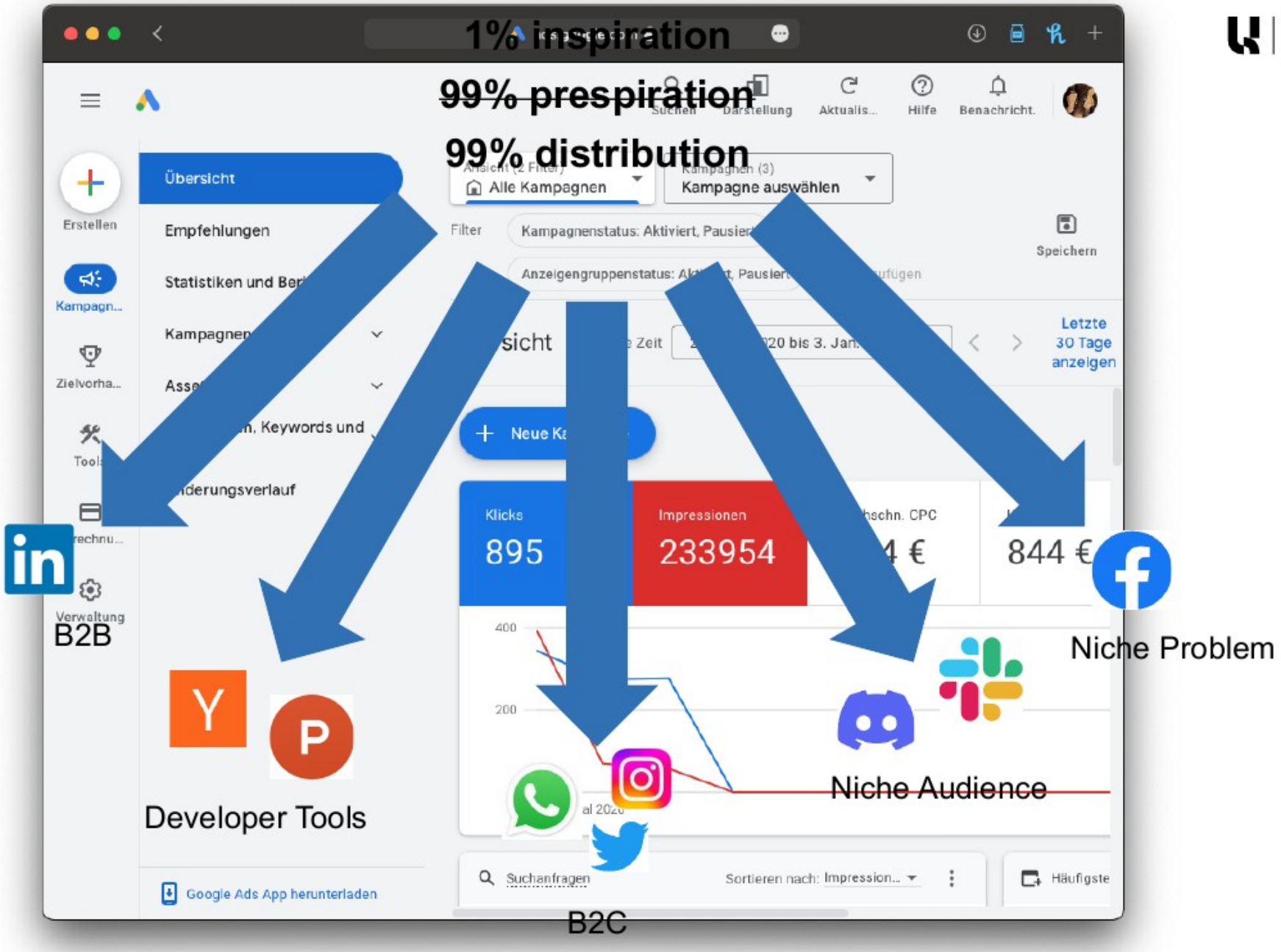
Temple of Nike

Blue Ribbon turn Nike

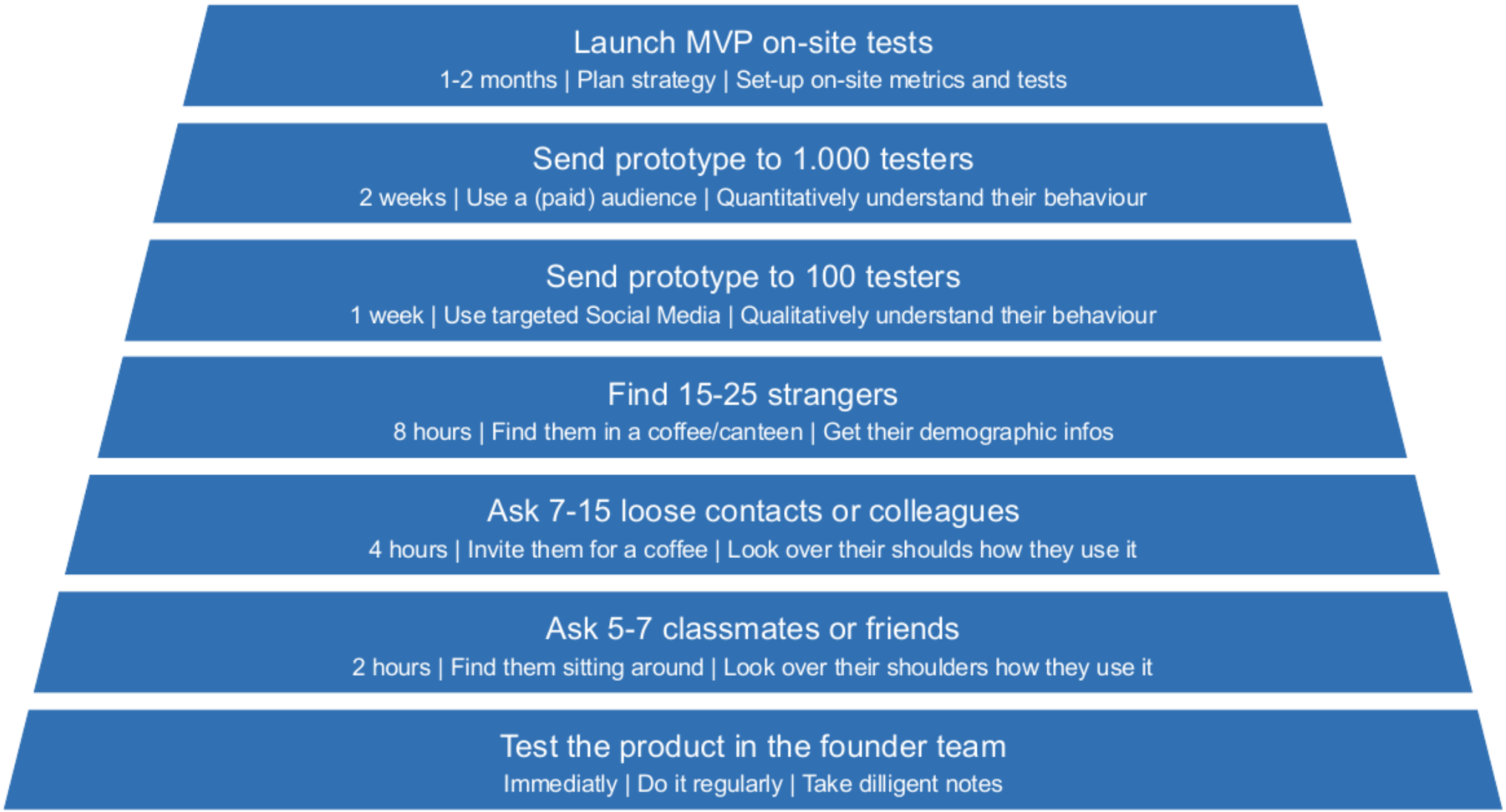
„Maybe it will grow on us“

# Growing a user community

A joint initiative by


1% inspiration
99% prespiration
99% distribution
Übersicht
Empfehlungen
Erstellen
Kampagn...
Zielvorha...
Tools
Verwaltung
Alle Kampagnen
Kampagne auswählen
Filter
Speichern
Letzte 30 Tage anzeigen
Neue Ka
Klicks
895
Impressionen
233954
844 €
400
200
Suchanfragen
Sortieren nach: Impression...
Häufigste
Google Ads App herunterladen
B2B
Developer Tools
Niche Problem
Niche Audience
B2C

# Testing your prototype






# Finding an Audience

- **Better done than perfect:** Use who you can find, even if they are not your perfect customer
- **Know your customers:** B2B goes to canteens, B2C sit in cafees, when do they have 10 mins
- **Give first, take second:** Offer them a beverage or snack for their time
- **Set yourself a target:** Don‘t leave before you spend at least 10 minutes with at least 7 people
- **Always follow through:** Never leave a loose end



# Building an Audience




- **Build Engagement early:** Talk about what you do, find people who are interested
- **Create a brand:** Use social media with memable posts to collect a following
- **Create Virality:** What do people get for forwarding your asks
- **Collect all leads:** Always allow opportunities to leave email addresses
- **Reach out:** Use Newsletters and LinkedIn Mails to get to your users

**Remember: Building begins in the problem space!**
**Your problem needs to be validated before the solution.**

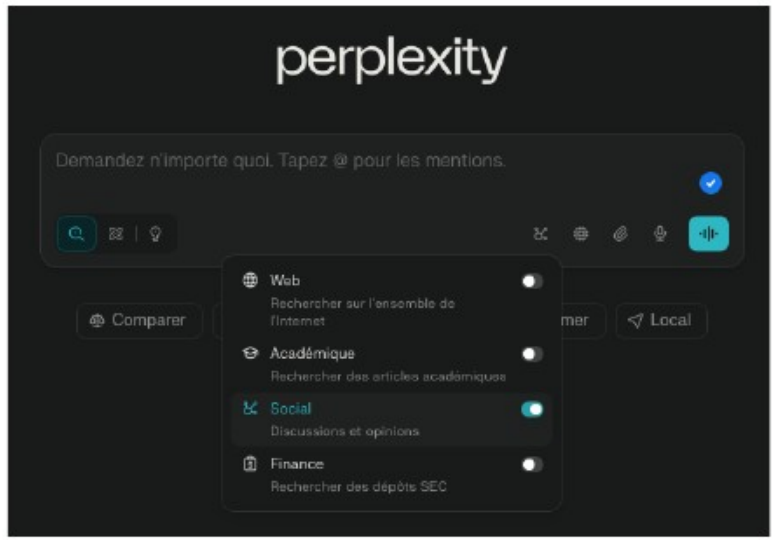
# Strategies involving Social Media

## Post Yourself:



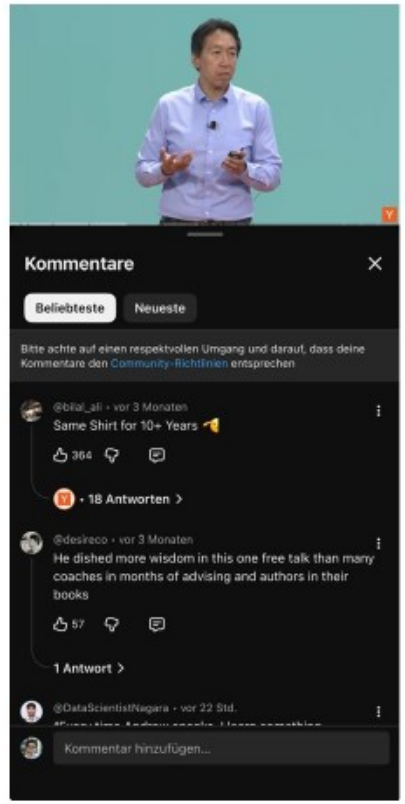

Scheduled job on your recent findings:
Create an engaging LinkedIn/… post

## Find the current trend:




Use websearch to find relevant posts
in your area of interest

## Like, Comment, & Subscribe:




AI not yet reliable… use your brain to interact
with existing content & communities

# Building an Audience




Post regularly:

- What did you find out? What is interesting?
- What is helpful for your audience?
- What is counterintuitive/controversial?
- What open questions do you still have?

Who interacts with your content?

- Reach out to them for more interviews
- Encourage reposting
- Interact with all comments

What does your audience look like?

- Demography
- Matches your hypotheses?
- Why or why not?

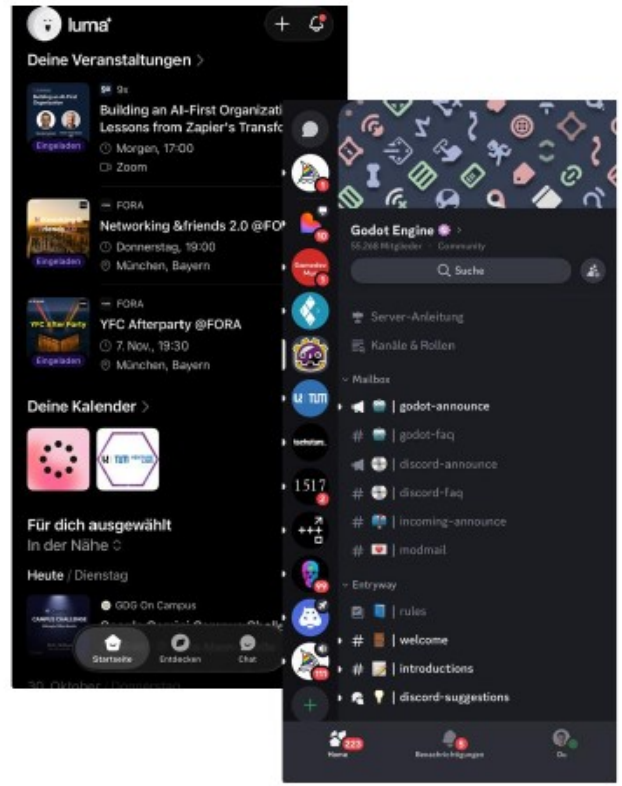
# Audiences beyond Social Media

## Specialist Media:



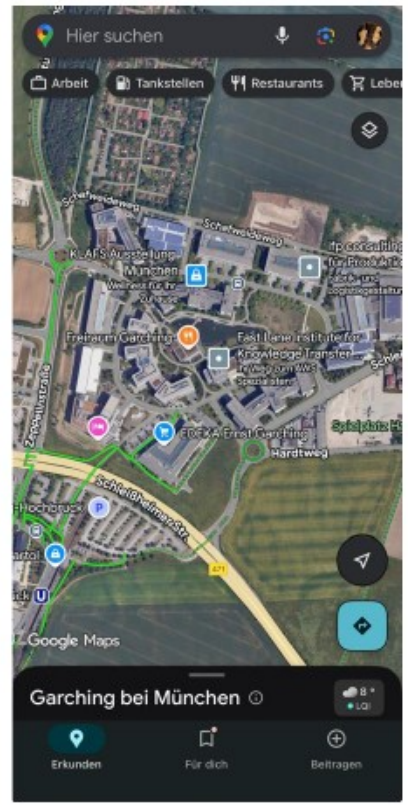

Use Perplexity or an AI search to find specialty media and then buy some of them

## Online Communities:



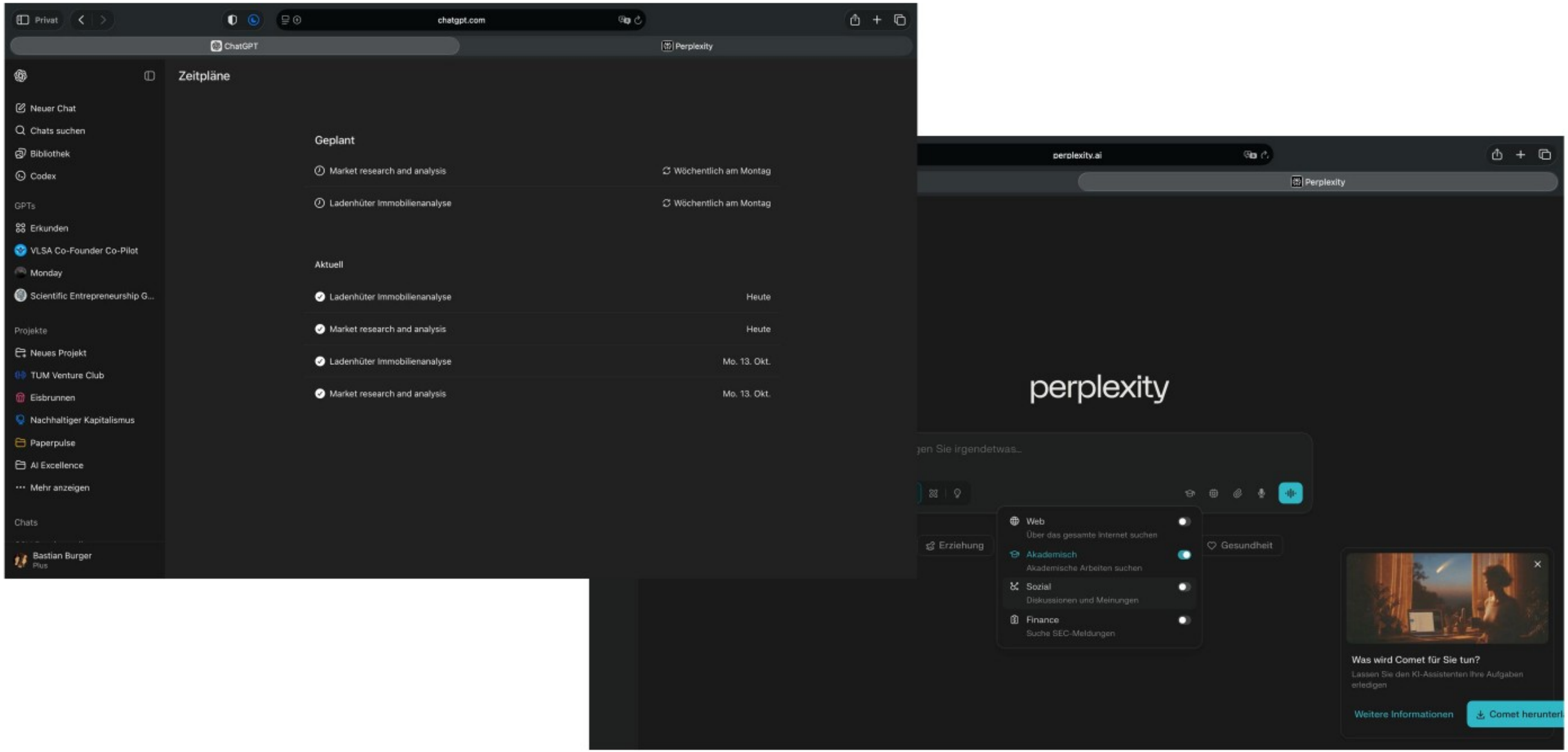

Use Agents (ChatGPT or MCP, schedules) to run on Luma, Eventbride, Meetup, Slack, Discord, WhatsApp

## Offline Communities:




AI not yet reliable… use your brain to find hot-spots, offices, hangouts, etc.

# It‘s a full-time job, let AI do the heavy lifting



# To validate your problem & solution:

**Get signups**

**Get active users**

**Get paying customers**

# Get out of the building to get every day at least 7 interactions

# Speed matters

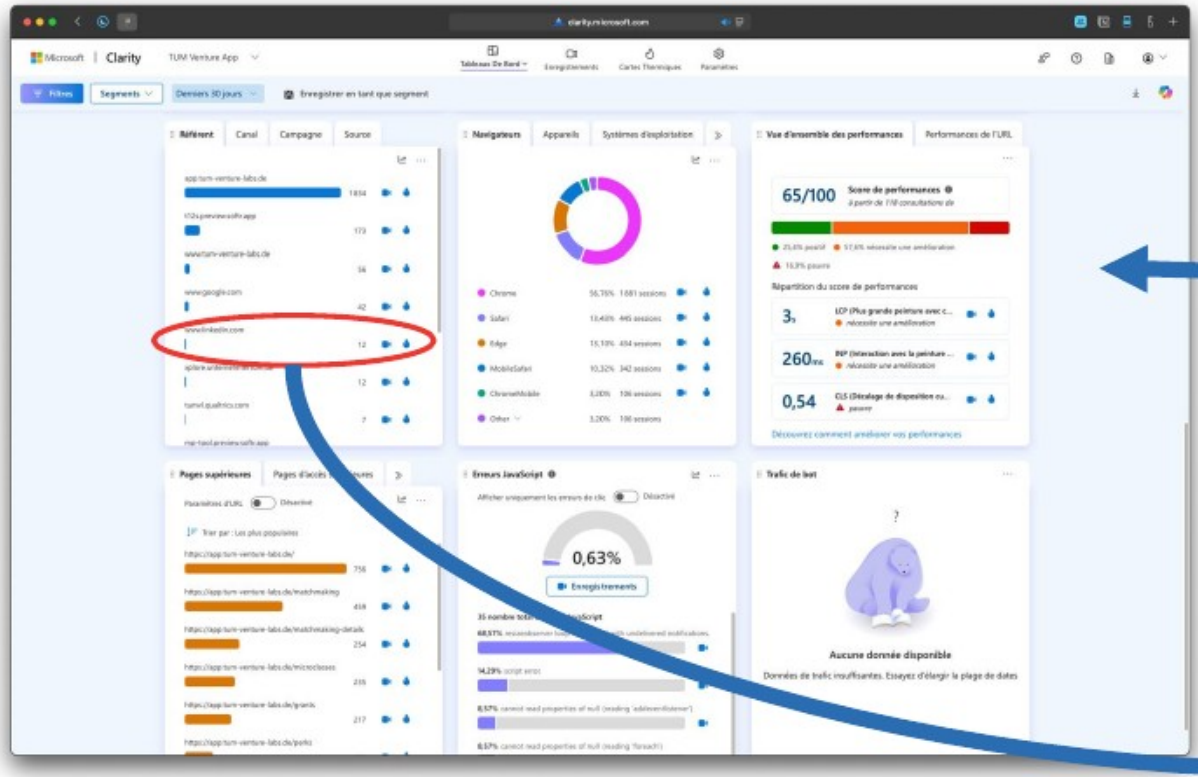
**Get out of th to get every day at least ctions**

10% CTR, 5% SUR, 7 daily signups:

Have **1.400 daily impressions!**



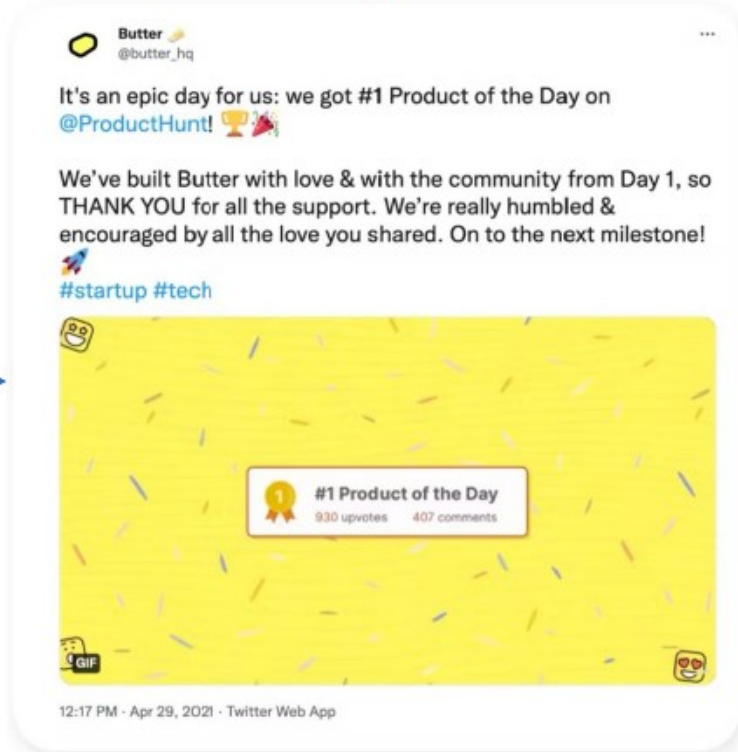
# Double Down on what works




Meassure your success

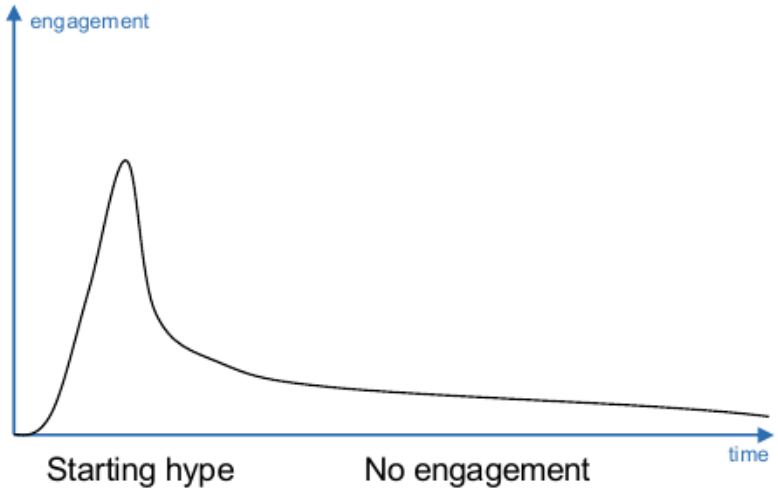
2x the input

> 2x the outcome?



# Monitoring engagement in a problem space

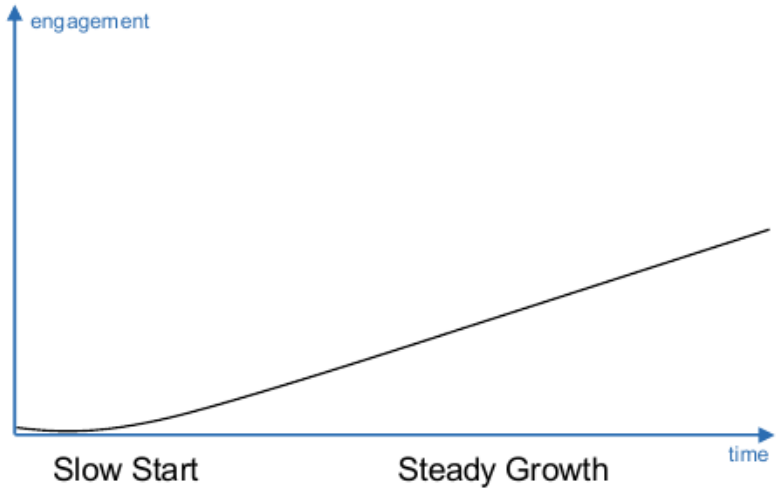
## Case 1: No Interest




Wrong target group/
Wrong problem/
Poor communication

**To-Do: Rework Problem Space**

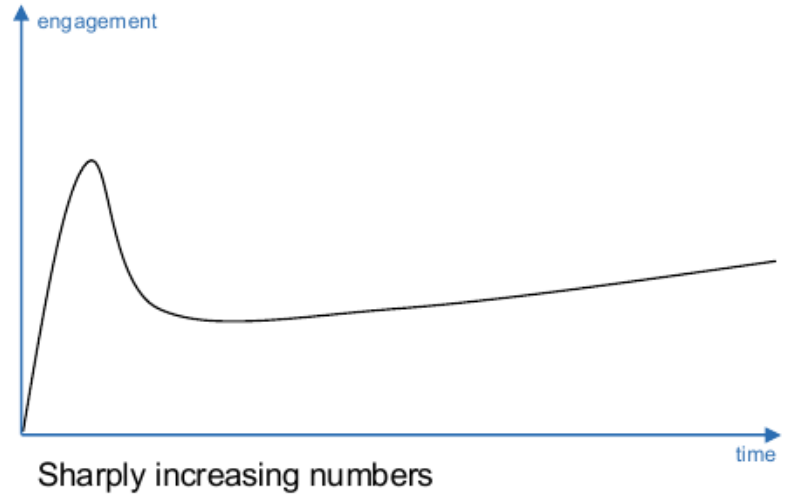
## Case 1: Organic Interest




Right target included/
Sustained interest/
Good communication

**To-Do: Identify user group**

## Artifact: External shock



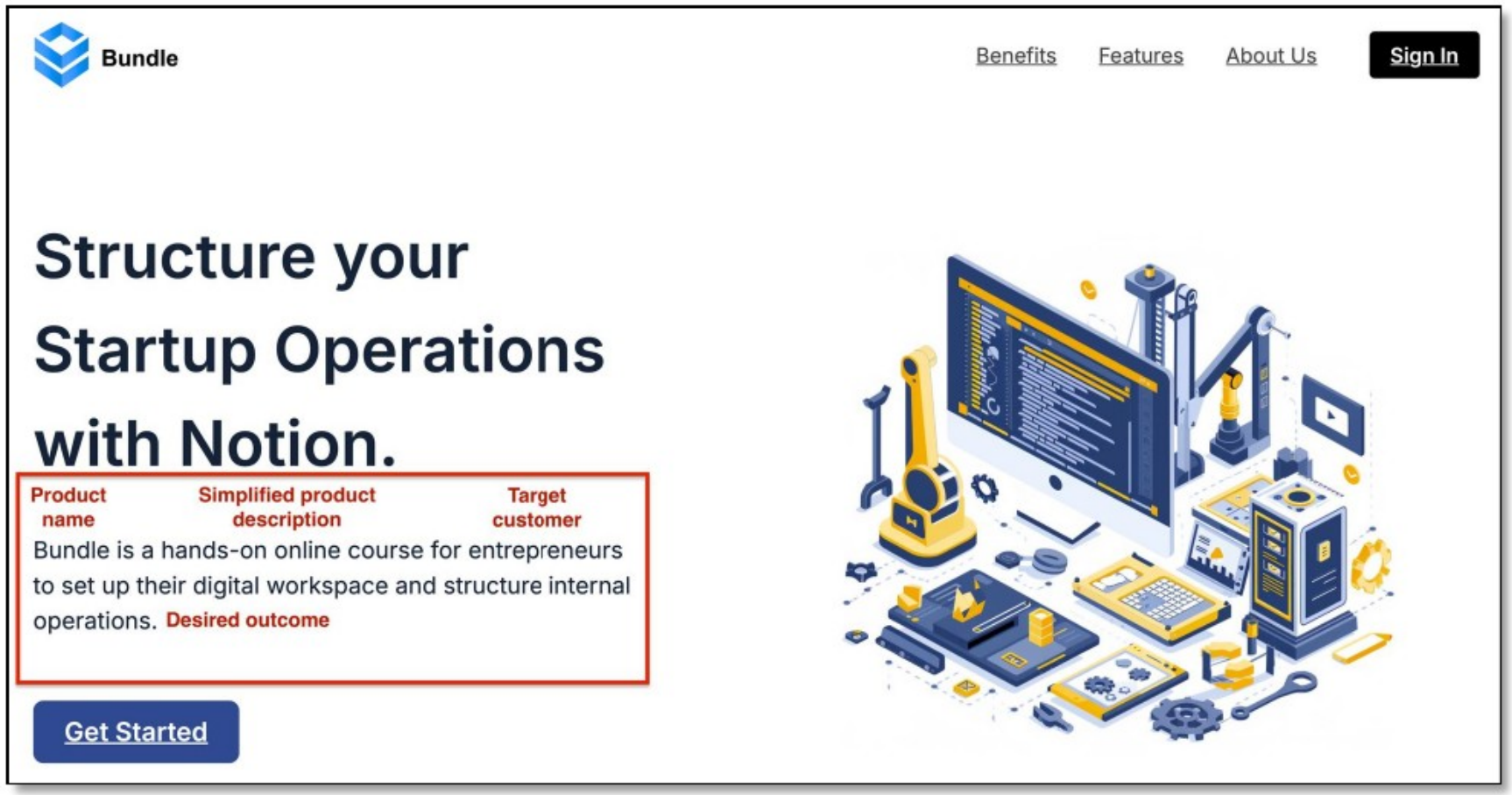

Newspaper article/
Social media event

**You want to look for dx/dt>0 for t>>0**

Impressions < Clicks < Sign-ups (Remember Hirarchie of evidence!)

## 2 One liner

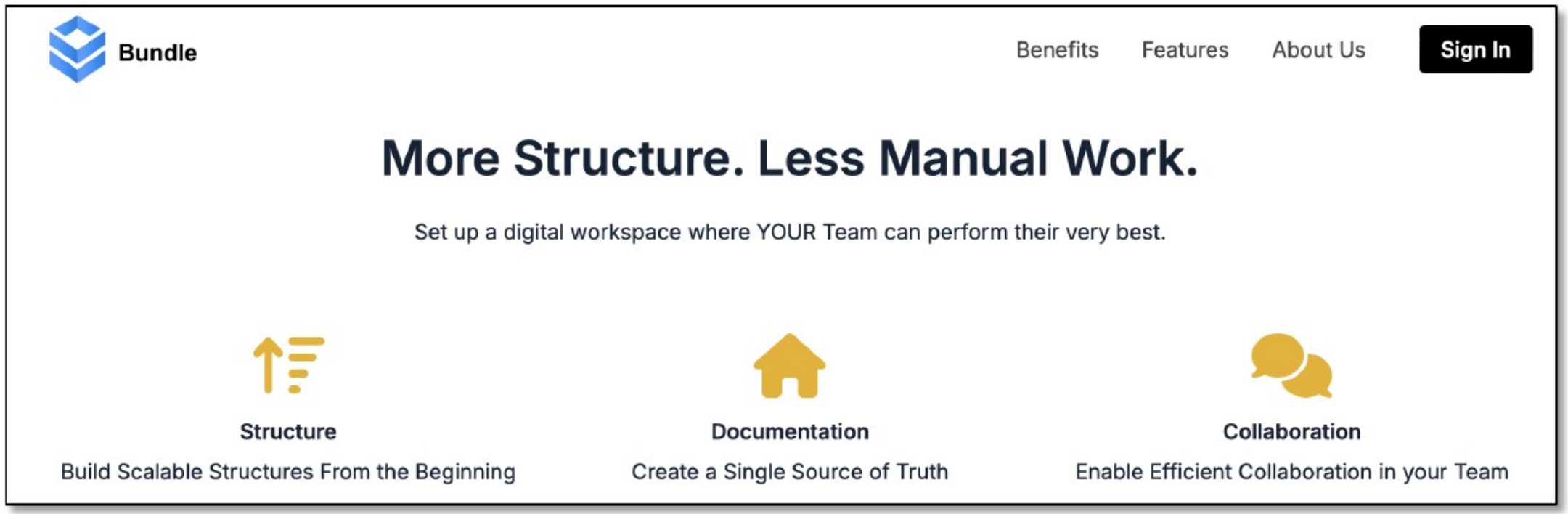
*More product oriented → describe the product and what it does for the customer*



# 3 Benefits

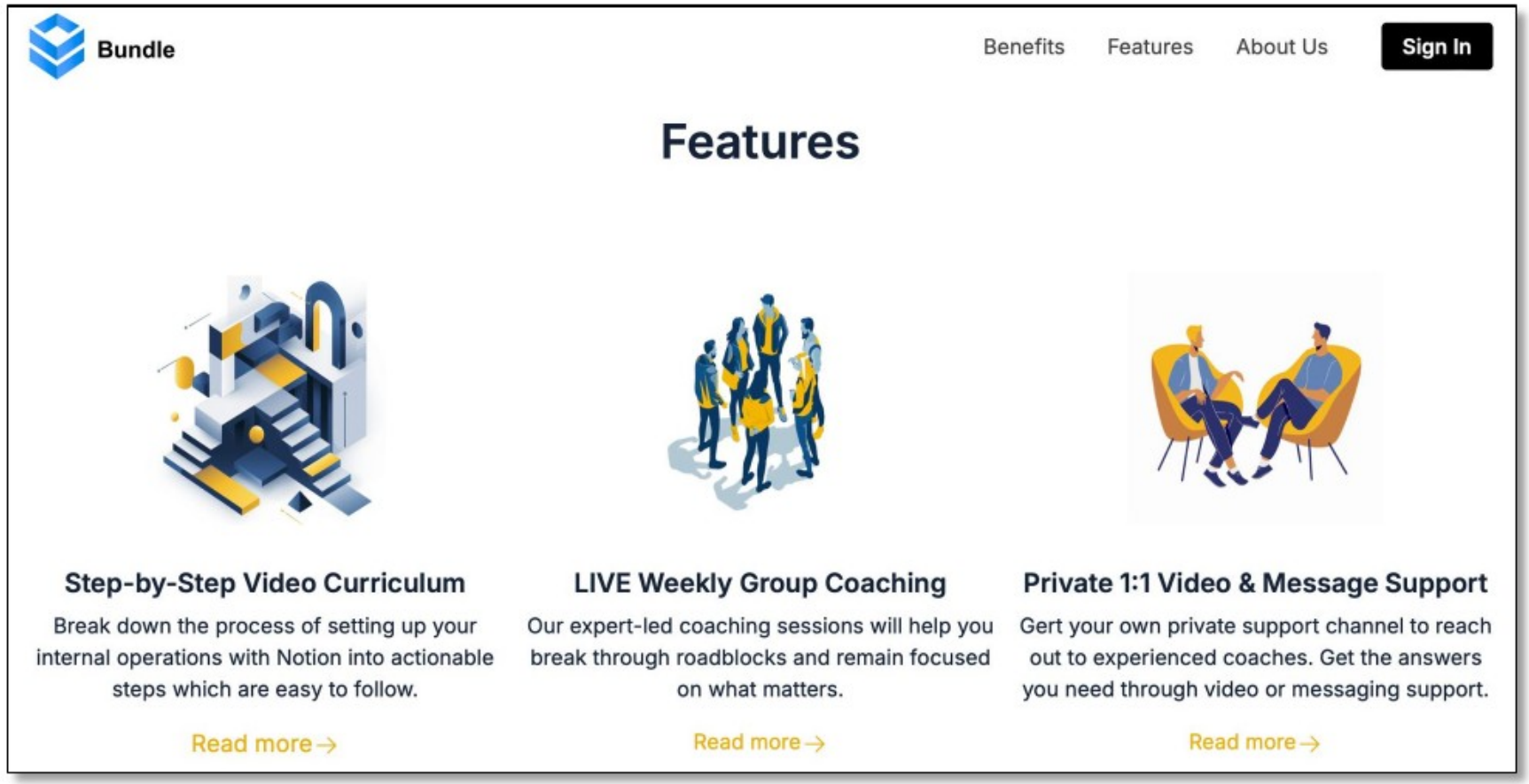
*Smaller benefits people are looking for in their journey to the ultimate outcome*

*Not to be mistaken with features of your product*



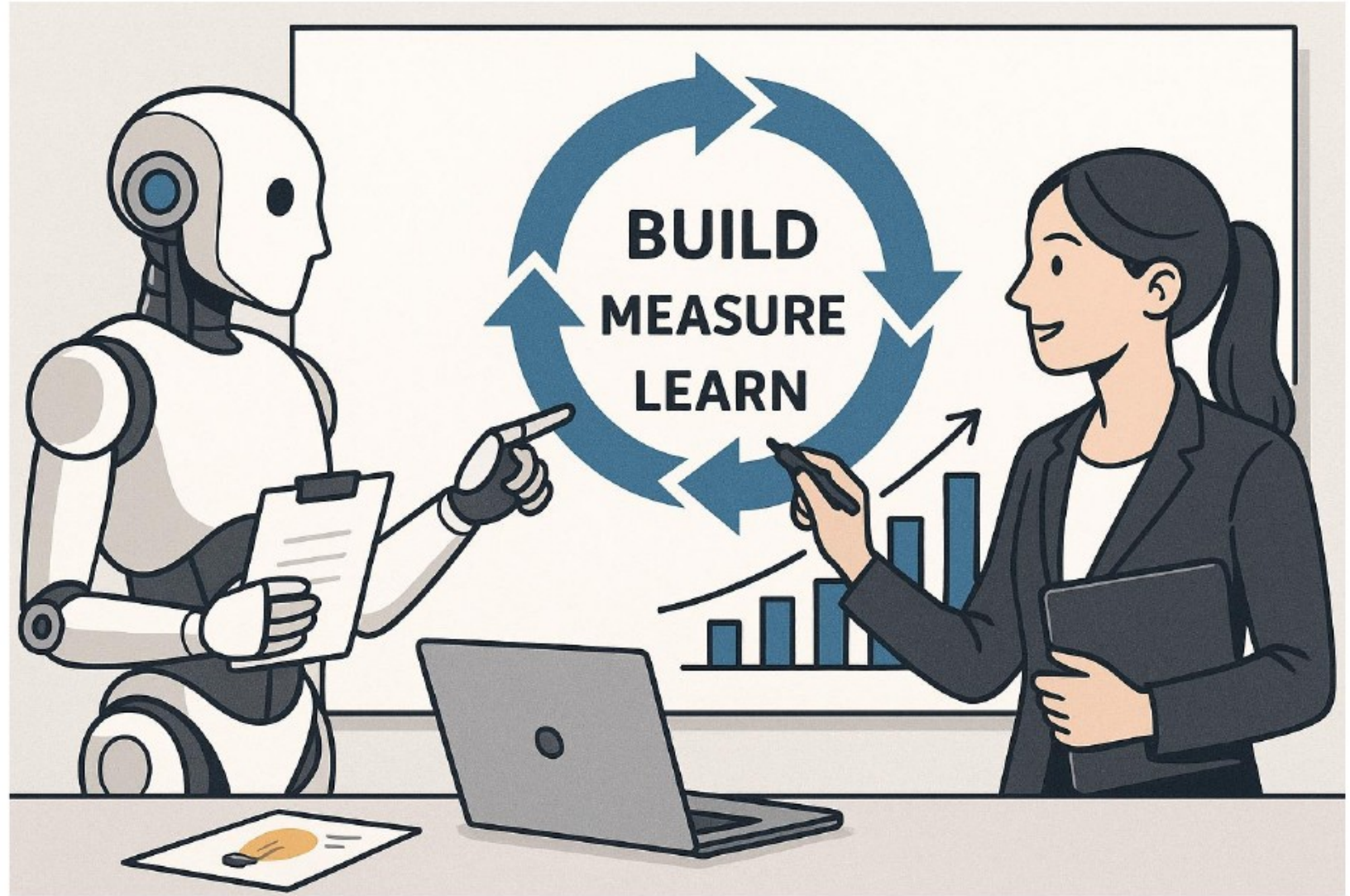
# 4 Key features

*3-4 features that allow you to deliver the benefits to the customers*



# Leveraging generative AI for Lean Startup: Core Principles

See generative AI as an assistant not as a substitute
Output of generative AI should be seen as a starting point, not as the final output
Generative AI can easily generate reasonable output, but it is difficult to get excellent output.



# Basics of Prompting

## Roles

- Describe the role of GenAI tool in your prompt
- Describe your role in the prompt

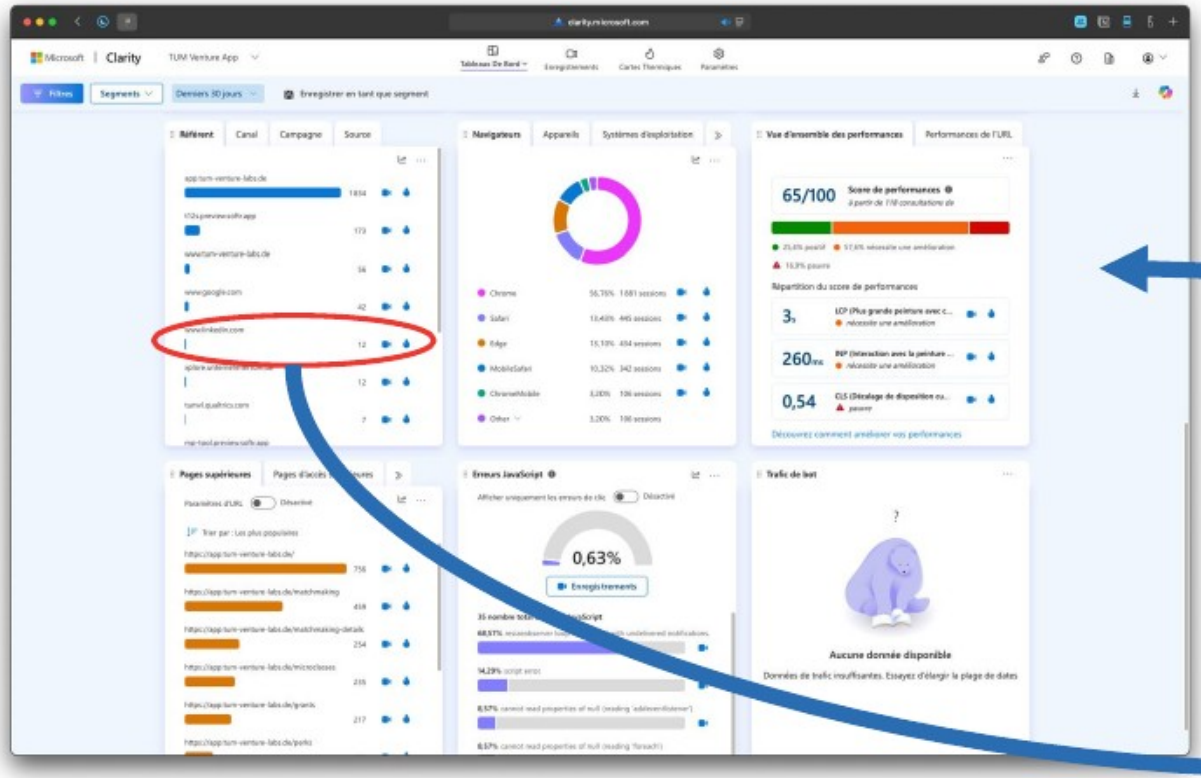
## Task

- Describe the goal of the task
- Provide a step-by-step explanation of how the GenAI tool should execute the task
- Provide rules that the GenAI tool should respect with executing the task

## Output

- Stipulate the type of output that you want to get
- Provide examples of input output transformations

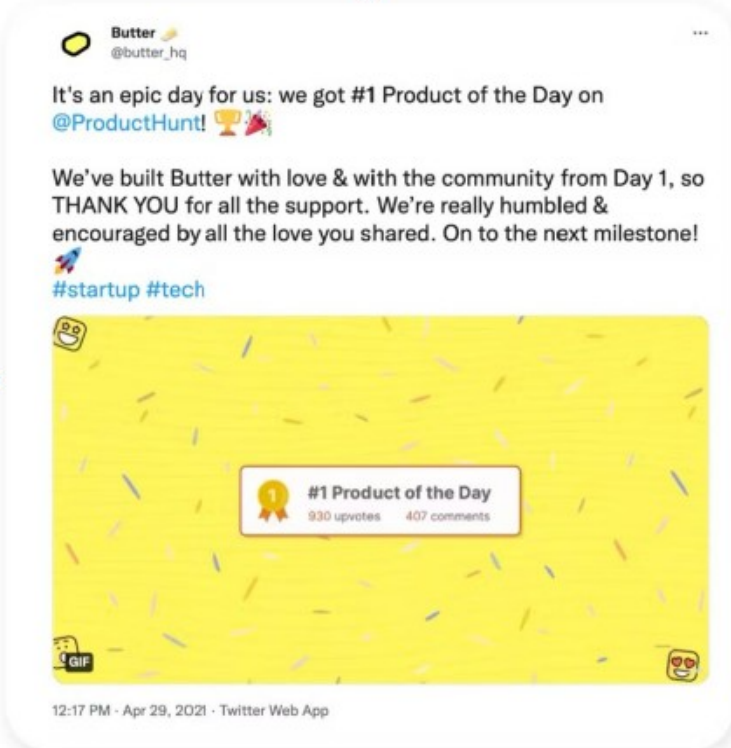
# Double Down on what works




Meassure your success

2x the input

> 2x the outcome?



# Reflection: Validation level

Do you feel like you can measure a SPECIFIC problem with your prototype?



When would you call your prototype a success, when a failure?



Do you know what to do now/tomorrow/this weekend?



# Assignment for home-work

1. Build a Landingpage about your problem
2. Launch it to the web – it's 10€ well spend
3. Generate at least 7 CTA interactions each week
4. Follow up with the visitors and learn more

# Thank You!

A joint initiative by